

# Uniform Bessel bounds for endpoint crossings in the persistent random walk

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## Abstract

We observe a ball bouncing down a Galton board, where its first bounce is fair and each later bounce repeats the previous one with probability  $p$ . We find the value of  $p$  at which the middle bin is exactly as likely as the end bins, a question posed by Kagey. For  $N$  bounces this is the value at which the ball turns about  $\log N$  times on average. The main tool compares the middle bin with a Bessel function along with an explicit error at every  $N$ . It gives an explicit interval for the tie for every  $N \geq 2$ . Large  $N$  is done analytically, and small  $N$  by exact integer arithmetic that we also checked in Lean. We also find the tie of every other bin and the shift caused by periodic boundaries.

**Keywords:** persistent random walk; correlated random walk; Galton board; Markov binomial distribution; Ising chain; modified Bessel functions; computer-assisted proof.

**MSC2020:** 60J10; 60F05; 82B20; 60G50; 33C10.

## 1 Introduction

### 1.1 Kagey's question

Problem 131 of Kagey's Open Problem Collection [1] is about a Galton board where the ball has momentum. The first bounce is fair. After that, each bounce goes the same way as the previous one with probability  $p$ . For  $p = \frac{1}{2}$  this is the usual board. The bin is binomial and the end bins are the least likely. For  $p$  close to 1 the ball rarely turns, so the end bins are the most likely.

Kagey asks five questions. What is the law of the bins? What do the tables of numerators for  $p = \frac{2}{3}$  and  $p = \frac{1}{3}$  count? At which  $p$  is the middle bin as likely as the end bins? Is there a normal limit? What changes on a cylinder? Most of this paper is about the third question.

With two steps there are three bins. The ball lands in the middle exactly when it turns once, so the bins have probabilities  $\frac{p}{2}$ ,  $1 - p$  and  $\frac{p}{2}$ , and they are level at  $p = \frac{2}{3}$ . This is why the third row of Kagey's table for  $p = \frac{2}{3}$  reads 2, 2, 2. With three steps the bins have probabilities  $\frac{p^2}{2}$ ,  $\frac{1-p^2}{2}$ ,  $\frac{1-p^2}{2}$  and  $\frac{p^2}{2}$ , and they are level at  $p = 1/\sqrt{2}$ . In general there is exactly one way to reach a given end bin, by never turning, and very many ways to reach the middle by turning a few times, each turn bringing a factor of about  $1 - p$ .

The middle bin and the end bins are level when the ball turns about  $\log N$  times on average, where  $N$  is the number of steps. More precisely, the crossing value  $p_N$  of  $p$  satisfies  $N(1 - p_N) = \log N - \frac{1}{2} \log \log N - 0.467 \dots + o(1)$ , and for every  $N \geq 2$  we trap  $N(1 - p_N)$  between two explicit

functions of  $N$  whose distance tends to 0 (Theorem 3.4). For  $p < p_N$  the middle is more likely, and for  $p > p_N$  the ends are.

The other questions have short answers. The law of the bins is a sum over the number of turns (Theorem 2.1), with a rational generating function (Proposition 2.2), and this is classical [18]. The numerators of Kagey's tables are weighted counts of words (Remark 2.3). For each fixed  $p \in (0, 1)$  the bin has a normal limit (Theorem 2.5). We do not treat the cylinder. Instead we close the sequence of steps into a loop, which gives the periodic Ising chain. This moves the central crossing by about  $(\log 2)/N$  in the odds  $(1 - p)/p$  (Section 5). Kagey also asks about boards with more directions, such as a tetrahedron. The companion paper [2] treats  $d$  directions, and more general chains and walks with memory are in preparation [3, 4].

## 1.2 Setting and notation

**The walk.** The ball makes  $N \geq 1$  steps. We record a run as a word  $w = w_1 \cdots w_N$  in the letters  $+$  (right) and  $-$  (left). The letter  $w_1$  is  $+$  or  $-$  with probability  $\frac{1}{2}$ , and given  $w_1, \dots, w_i$ ,

$$\mathbb{P}(w_{i+1} = w_i) = p, \quad \mathbb{P}(w_{i+1} \neq w_i) = q = 1 - p.$$

An index  $i < N$  with  $w_i \neq w_{i+1}$  is a *switch*. Let  $\text{chg}(w)$  be the number of switches and  $\text{rep}(w) = N - 1 - \text{chg}(w)$ . Then

$$\mathbb{P}(w) = \frac{1}{2} p^{\text{rep}(w)} q^{\text{chg}(w)}. \quad (1)$$

For  $p > 0$  we put  $u = q/p$ , the odds of a switch.

**Bins.** The ball lands in bin  $k$  if  $w$  has  $k$  letters  $+$ , for  $0 \leq k \leq N$ . We write  $P_N(k)$  for the probability of bin  $k$ , and  $P_0(0) = 1$ . Bins 0 and  $N$  are the *endpoints*. Only the constant word  $-\cdots-$  reaches bin 0, and only  $+\cdots+$  reaches bin  $N$ , so

$$P_N(0) = P_N(N) = \frac{1}{2} p^{N-1} \quad (N \geq 1).$$

A middle bin is  $m_N = \lfloor N/2 \rfloor$ . For odd  $N$  the two middle bins have equal probability by symmetry. Row  $n$  of the tables of the problem has  $n$  bins, so it is our  $N = n - 1$ . For  $p = \alpha/(\alpha + \beta)$  with integers  $\alpha, \beta \geq 0$ , not both 0, the numerator of bin  $k$  in those tables is  $n_N(k) = 2(\alpha + \beta)^{N-1} P_N(k)$  (Remark 2.3).

**Spins.** Put  $\sigma_i = +1$  if  $w_i = +$  and  $\sigma_i = -1$  if  $w_i = -$ , and  $X_N = \sigma_1 + \cdots + \sigma_N$ . The bin is  $K_N = (N + X_N)/2$ . Since  $\text{chg}(w) = \sum_{i < N} (1 - \sigma_i \sigma_{i+1})/2$ , (1) gives  $\mathbb{P}(w) \propto \exp(J \sum_{i < N} \sigma_i \sigma_{i+1})$  with  $e^{-2J} = u$ . So the spins form the Ising chain in zero field with free boundaries, and  $J > 0$  exactly when  $p > \frac{1}{2}$ .

**Scales.** Let  $L = \log N$  and  $T = Nq$ . Each of the  $N - 1$  steps after the first switches with probability  $q$ , so the expected number of switches is  $(N - 1)q = T - q$ . We call  $T$  the *switching scale*. The central crossing has  $T$  of order  $L$ . Near the edges the crossings have larger  $T$ , up to order  $\sqrt{N}$  for the bins next to an edge (Section 4).

**Ratios and crossings.** For a bin  $k$  with  $1 \leq k \leq N-1$  we write  $a = k$  and  $b = N - k$  for its numbers of letters  $+$  and  $-$ . For  $p > 0$  the ratio of bin  $k$  to an endpoint depends on  $p$  only through  $u$ , and it is a polynomial in  $u$  with nonnegative integer coefficients ((13) below). We write

$$S_{a,b}(u) = \frac{P_N(a)}{P_N(0)}, \quad S_N(u) = S_{m_N, N-m_N}(u)$$

for this ratio and for its value at the middle. *The crossing* of bin  $k$  is the value of  $p$  at which bin  $k$  is exactly as likely as an endpoint, that is,  $S_{a,b}(u) = 1$ . It is unique (Section 4), and we write  $p_{a,b}$  for it and  $u_{a,b} = (1 - p_{a,b})/p_{a,b}$  for its odds. The *central crossing* is  $p_N = p_{m_N, N-m_N}$ , with odds  $u_N$ , and

$$z_N = N(1 - p_N) = \frac{Nu_N}{1 + u_N} \quad (2)$$

is the value of  $T$  there.

**Special functions and asymptotic notation.**  $I_0$  and  $I_1$  are the modified Bessel functions of the first kind. We use them through their power series and their behavior at infinity [21, Eqs. 10.25.2, 10.40.1],

$$I_0(2x) = \sum_{r \geq 0} \frac{x^{2r}}{(r!)^2}, \quad I_1(2x) = \sum_{r \geq 0} \frac{x^{2r+1}}{r!(r+1)!}, \quad I_\nu(z) = \frac{e^z}{\sqrt{2\pi z}} \left(1 - \frac{4\nu^2 - 1}{8z} + O(z^{-2})\right)$$

as  $z \rightarrow \infty$ , for  $\nu = 0, 1$ . We write  $f \sim g$  if  $f/g \rightarrow 1$ . Each  $O(\cdot)$  comes with the parameters it is uniform in, and  $O_a(\cdot)$  means that the constant may depend on  $a$ .

### 1.3 Main results

**A Bessel bound at every  $N$ .** Put  $h = N/2$  and  $F(x) = 2x(I_0(2x) + I_1(2x))$ . Theorem 3.3 says that for every  $N \geq 2$  and every  $x > 0$ ,

$$0 \leq 1 - \frac{hS_N(x/h)}{F(x)} \leq \frac{x(x+1)}{h}.$$

Near the crossing  $x = Nu/2$  is about  $L/2$ , so the relative error is  $O(L^2/N)$ . Theorem 4.3 gives the same kind of bound for every bin, with relative error at most  $Nu^2/2 + u$ .

**The central crossing at every  $N$ .** Let  $\zeta_N$  be the positive root of  $8\zeta e^{2\zeta} = \pi N^2$ , that is,  $\zeta_N = \frac{1}{2}W_0(\pi N^2/4)$  with  $W_0$  the principal branch of Lambert's function, and let  $\varepsilon_N = \zeta_N(\zeta_N + 1)/N + 1/(16\zeta_N^2)$ . Theorem 3.4 says that

$$\zeta_N + \frac{1}{8\zeta_N} - \varepsilon_N < z_N < \zeta_N + \frac{1}{8\zeta_N} \quad \text{for every } N \geq 2.$$

Note that  $\varepsilon_N \rightarrow 0$ . For  $N \geq 175$  the proof is analytic. For  $2 \leq N \leq 174$  we decide the sign of  $S_N - 1$  at two rationals, one on each side of the root, in exact integer arithmetic, and the Lean kernel repeats this check. The theorem has two simpler consequences. With  $c_0 = \frac{1}{2} \log(\pi/8) = -0.467\dots$ , the crossing satisfies

$$z_N + \frac{1}{2} \log z_N = L + c_0 + \frac{1}{8z_N} + R_N, \quad |R_N| \leq \frac{1}{4L^2} + \frac{L^2 + L}{N} \quad (N \geq 2)$$

(Proposition 3.8), and as  $N \rightarrow \infty$

$$z_N = L - \frac{1}{2} \log L + c_0 + \frac{\frac{1}{4} \log L - \frac{1}{2} c_0 + \frac{1}{8}}{L} + O\left(\frac{(\log L)^2}{L^2}\right)$$

(Corollary 3.7). The convergence is slow, and  $z_N/L$  is still only 0.84 at  $N = 10^4$  (Figure 2).

**Every bin.** Let bin  $a$  be at distance  $a$  from the nearer edge, with  $b = N - a \geq a$ . Next to the edge the crossing is at  $p_N^{\text{adj}} = (1 + \sqrt{N-1})/(2 + \sqrt{N-1})$ , and at the central crossing these two bins are the least likely of all (Proposition 4.2). As  $a \rightarrow \infty$ , Theorem 4.7 expands  $2\sqrt{ab}u_{a,b}$  to the same order as  $z_N$ , uniformly in  $b \geq a$ . For fixed  $a$  the crossing comes instead from a Laguerre polynomial. Then  $u_{a,b} = c_a/\sqrt{b} - 1/b + O_a(b^{-3/2})$ , where  $c_a^2$  is the positive root of an explicit polynomial of degree  $a$  (Theorem 4.8). The two regimes match (Theorem 4.9).

**Periodic boundaries.** If the steps are closed into a loop, so that the last step also interacts with the first, the central crossing moves by  $(\log 2)/N$  in the odds to leading order (Theorem 5.2). Under either boundary, at odds  $u_N^X + t/N$ , where  $u_N^X$  is the central crossing of that boundary, the ratio of bin  $N/2 + yN/\sqrt{\log N}$  to an endpoint tends to  $e^{t-2y^2}$  (Theorem 5.3).

Sections 2 to 5 prove these results in this order, Section 6 lists what was computed and what is in Lean, and the appendix holds the longer proofs of Section 3.

## 1.4 Related work

The correlated random walk goes back to Goldstein [13] and Gillis [12]. Renshaw and Henderson [18] study the same symmetric model, motivated by a Galton machine. They give the exact law from run counts, the generating function, the normal limit and the upturn at the endpoints, and in their Section 4 a Bessel limit at a fixed persistence scale, followed by a limit as that scale grows. Since the two limits are taken one after the other, there is no error bound at finite  $N$  when the scale grows like  $\log N$ , which is where the crossing happens. Konno [15] writes the exact law with the hypergeometric function  ${}_2F_1$  and proves the telegraph limit when  $p = 1 - \theta/N$  with  $\theta$  fixed, again a fixed scale. Herrmann and Vallois [14] give the telegraph limit with its Bessel density. Dekking and Kong [10] study the Markov binomial law, give its variance and find when it has one, two or three modes. Their criterion already gives the crossing of the bins next to the edges (Section 4.1). The OEIS entries [16, 17] already record both tables of the problem.

For the Ising chain, Antal, Droz and Rácz [5] give the magnetization law at a fixed scale  $T$  under several boundary conditions, and Dantchev and Rudnick [9] give exact free and periodic coefficients. Stepanyan et al. [19, Section III.B] study the periodic endpoint–adjacent and endpoint–center crossings directly, so the crossing question itself is not new. The new results here are bounds at finite  $N$  when  $T$  is of order  $\log N$ , also near the edges. The Markov binomial estimates of Čekanavičius and Mikalauskas [7, 8] assume ranges of the transition probabilities that exclude  $p \rightarrow 1$ .

## 2 The exact law

The results of this section are classical [18, 10]. We prove Theorem 2.1 because the later sections use its count of words by switches. By (1), a word with  $j$  switches has probability  $\frac{1}{2}p^{N-1-j}q^j$ .

**Theorem 2.1** (bin probabilities). *Let  $N \geq 1$ . Then  $P_N(0) = P_N(N) = \frac{1}{2}p^{N-1}$ , and for  $1 \leq k \leq N-1$*

$$P_N(k) = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{j=1}^{N-1} W(N, k, j) p^{N-1-j} q^j,$$

where, writing  $a = k$  and  $b = N - k$ ,

$$W(N, k, 2i-1) = 2 \binom{a-1}{i-1} \binom{b-1}{i-1}, \quad W(N, k, 2i) = \binom{a-1}{i} \binom{b-1}{i-1} + \binom{a-1}{i-1} \binom{b-1}{i}$$

is the number of words with  $a$  letters  $+$ ,  $b$  letters  $-$  and exactly  $j$  switches.

*Proof.* By (1) it suffices to count the words in bin  $k$  with  $j$  switches. We count them by their run lengths. A word with  $j$  switches consists of  $j+1$  maximal runs, alternately of letters  $+$  and of letters  $-$ . If  $k \in \{0, N\}$  there is one word and it has no switch. Let  $a, b \geq 1$ . If  $j+1 = 2i$  there are  $i$  runs of each letter. The run lengths form a composition of  $a$  into  $i$  parts and a composition of  $b$  into  $i$  parts, and there are  $\binom{a-1}{i-1} \binom{b-1}{i-1}$  such pairs. The two choices of the first letter give the factor 2. If  $j+1 = 2i+1$  the word starts and ends with the same letter. Starting with  $+$  gives  $i+1$  runs of  $+$  and  $i$  runs of  $-$ , so  $\binom{a-1}{i} \binom{b-1}{i-1}$  words, and starting with  $-$  gives the other summand.  $\square$

For instance  $P_2 = (\frac{p}{2}, q, \frac{p}{2})$ ,  $P_3(1) = \frac{1}{2}(1-p^2)$  and  $P_4(2) = q(1-p+p^2)$ . Each interior bin needs at least one switch, while the endpoints need none. So the endpoints win when  $p$  is close to 1, and Section 3 asks how close.

**Proposition 2.2** (recurrence and generating function). *Let  $P_N^+(k)$  and  $P_N^-(k)$  be the probabilities of being in bin  $k$  after  $N$  steps with last letter  $+$ , respectively  $-$ , and set them to 0 outside  $0 \leq k \leq N$ . Then  $P_1^+(1) = P_1^-(0) = \frac{1}{2}$ ,  $P_1^+(0) = P_1^-(1) = 0$ , and for  $N \geq 2$*

$$P_N^+(k) = p P_{N-1}^+(k-1) + q P_{N-1}^-(k-1), \quad P_N^-(k) = p P_{N-1}^-(k) + q P_{N-1}^+(k). \quad (3)$$

Consequently

$$\sum_{N \geq 0} \sum_{k=0}^N P_N(k) x^k t^N = \frac{1 - (p - \frac{1}{2})(1+x)t}{1 - p(1+x)t + (2p-1)xt^2}, \quad (4)$$

and for all  $N \geq 2$  and all  $k$ , with  $P_M(k) = 0$  outside  $0 \leq k \leq M$ ,

$$P_N(k) = p(P_{N-1}(k) + P_{N-1}(k-1)) - (2p-1)P_{N-2}(k-1). \quad (5)$$

*Proof.* The recursion (3) follows by conditioning on  $w_{N-1}$ , since  $w_N$  equals  $w_{N-1}$  with probability  $p$ . Let  $H^+ = \sum_{N,k} P_N^+(k) x^k t^N$  and define  $H^-$  alike. By (3),  $H^+ = xt(\frac{1}{2} + pH^+ + qH^-)$  and  $H^- = t(\frac{1}{2} + pH^- + qH^+)$ . Solving these two linear equations and adding 1 for  $N=0$  gives (4), which is the generating function of Renshaw and Henderson [18] in our notation. Multiplying (4) by its denominator and comparing the coefficients of  $x^k t^N$  with  $N \geq 2$  gives (5).  $\square$

**Remark 2.3** (numerator tables). For  $p = \alpha/(\alpha + \beta)$  with integers  $\alpha, \beta \geq 0$ , not both 0, the numerators of the tables of the problem are  $n_N(k) = 2(\alpha + \beta)^{N-1} P_N(k)$  for  $N \geq 1$ , not reduced. By (1),  $n_N(k)$  is the sum of  $\alpha^{\text{rep}(w)} \beta^{\text{chg}(w)}$  over the words with  $k$  letters  $+$  and  $N-k$  letters  $-$ , which shows that it is an integer.

## 2.1 Variance and the normal limit

Note that  $K_N$  counts the visits of the chain  $w_1, \dots, w_N$  to the letter  $+$ . This chain leaves each letter with probability  $q$  and starts from its stationary law  $(\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2})$ . So  $K_N$  has the Markov binomial law  $\text{Bin}(N, q, q, (\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}))$  of Dekking and Kong [10], whose second eigenvalue is  $1 - 2q = 2p - 1$ .

**Proposition 2.4** (mean and variance). *Let  $0 < p < 1$  and  $\rho = 2p - 1$ . Then  $\mathbb{E}K_N = N/2$  and*

$$\text{Var } K_N = \frac{1}{4} \left( N \frac{1 + \rho}{1 - \rho} - \frac{2\rho(1 - \rho^N)}{(1 - \rho)^2} \right) = \frac{Np}{4(1 - p)} - \frac{(2p - 1)(1 - (2p - 1)^N)}{8(1 - p)^2}.$$

*Proof.* This is [10, Eq. (2.3) and Proposition 2.1] with  $a = b = q$  and the stationary start, for which both excentricities vanish and both stationary weights are  $\frac{1}{2}$ . The second form follows from  $(1 + \rho)/(1 - \rho) = p/q$  and  $1 - \rho = 2q$ .  $\square$

**Theorem 2.5** (normal limit). *Let  $0 < p < 1$  be fixed. Then  $(K_N - N/2)/\sqrt{N}$  converges in distribution, as  $N \rightarrow \infty$ , to the normal law with mean 0 and variance  $p/(4(1 - p))$ .*

So persistence keeps the bell shape but widens it by the factor  $\sqrt{p/q}$  compared with the ordinary board.

*Proof.* Let  $v_N(\theta)$  be the vector with entries  $\mathbb{E}[e^{i\theta X_N}; \sigma_N = \pm 1]$ . By (3),  $v_{N+1} = Mv_N$  with

$$M = \begin{pmatrix} pe^{i\theta} & qe^{i\theta} \\ qe^{-i\theta} & pe^{-i\theta} \end{pmatrix}, \quad \text{tr } M = 2p \cos \theta, \quad \det M = 2p - 1.$$

At  $\theta = 0$  the eigenvalues are 1 and  $2p - 1$ , which are distinct. So for small  $|\theta|$  the matrix  $M$  has the simple eigenvalue  $\lambda_+(\theta) = p \cos \theta + \sqrt{q^2 - p^2 \sin^2 \theta} = 1 - \frac{p}{2q} \theta^2 + O(\theta^4)$  and the other eigenvalue stays near  $2p - 1$ , with spectral projections  $\Pi_{\pm}(\theta)$  that depend continuously on  $\theta$ , because the two eigenvalues are simple. Write  $\mathbf{1} = (1, 1)$ . Then  $\mathbb{E}e^{i\theta X_N} = \mathbf{1} \cdot M^{N-1} v_1(\theta) = \lambda_+^{N-1} \mathbf{1} \cdot \Pi_+ v_1 + \lambda_-^{N-1} \mathbf{1} \cdot \Pi_- v_1$ . The vector  $v_1(0) = (\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2})$  is an eigenvector of  $M$  for the eigenvalue 1 at  $\theta = 0$ , so  $\mathbf{1} \cdot \Pi_+ v_1 \rightarrow 1$  as  $\theta \rightarrow 0$ , while  $|\lambda_-| \rightarrow |2p - 1| < 1$ . Put  $\theta = s/\sqrt{N}$  with  $s$  fixed. Then the second term tends to 0, and the first tends to  $\exp(-\frac{p}{2q} s^2)$  since  $(N - 1) \log \lambda_+(s/\sqrt{N}) \rightarrow -\frac{p}{2q} s^2$ . By Lévy's continuity theorem [6, Theorem 26.3],  $X_N/\sqrt{N}$  converges to the normal law with variance  $p/q$ . Finally  $K_N - N/2 = X_N/2$ .  $\square$

## 3 The central crossing at every $N$

Let  $N \geq 2$ , let  $m_N = \lfloor N/2 \rfloor$  and let  $p > 0$ . By Theorem 2.1 the ratio of the middle bin to an endpoint is

$$\frac{P_N(m_N)}{P_N(0)} = S_N(u) := \sum_{j=1}^{N-1} W(N, m_N, j) u^j, \quad (6)$$

a polynomial in  $u$  with nonnegative integer coefficients and  $W(N, m_N, 1) = 2$ . The middle and the endpoints are level exactly when  $S_N(u) = 1$ .

The following heuristic explains why this happens when  $T$  is near  $\log N$ . Let  $a = m_N$  and  $b = N - m_N$ , both about  $N/2$ . A word in the middle bin with  $2r + 1$  switches has  $r + 1$  runs of each letter, and there are  $2 \binom{a-1}{r} \binom{b-1}{r} \approx 2(N/2)^{2r} / (r!)^2$  of them when  $r$  is small compared with  $\sqrt{N}$ . So these words contribute about  $2u \sum_r (Nu/2)^{2r} / (r!)^2 = 2u I_0(Nu)$  to  $S_N(u)$ , and in the same

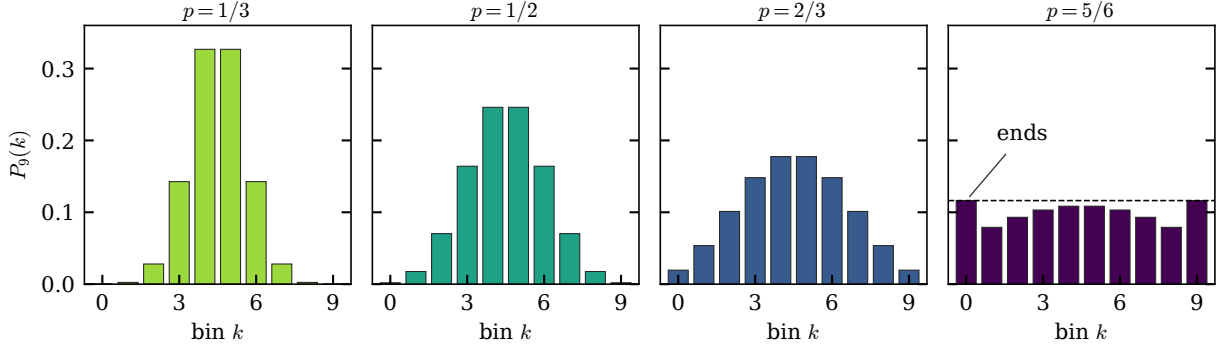


Figure 1: The bin probabilities  $P_9(k)$  of the tenth row for  $p = \frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{2}{3}, \frac{5}{6}$ . At  $p = \frac{5}{6}$ , just above  $p_9$ , the two middle bins are slightly below the endpoints (dashed line).

way the words with an even number of switches contribute about  $2uI_1(Nu)$ . For large  $w = Nu$  we have  $I_0(w) + I_1(w) \approx 2e^w/\sqrt{2\pi w}$ , so  $S_N(u) \approx 4we^w/(N\sqrt{2\pi w})$ . Setting this equal to 1 gives  $w + \frac{1}{2}\log w \approx L + \frac{1}{2}\log(\pi/8)$ . So at the crossing  $w$ , and with it  $T$ , is close to  $L - \frac{1}{2}\log L + c_0$  with  $c_0 = \frac{1}{2}\log(\pi/8)$ .

**Theorem 3.1.** (a) For every  $N \geq 2$  there is exactly one  $p = p_N \in [0, 1]$  with  $P_N(m_N) = P_N(0)$ , and  $p_N \geq \frac{2}{3}$ . The middle is more likely than the endpoints for  $p < p_N$  and less likely for  $p > p_N$ .

(b)  $p_2 = \frac{2}{3}$ ,  $p_3 = 1/\sqrt{2}$ ,  $p_4$  is the real root of  $3p^3 - 4p^2 + 4p - 2$ , and  $p_N < p_{N+1}$  for all  $N \geq 2$ .

(c)  $p_N \rightarrow 1$  as  $N \rightarrow \infty$ , and more precisely  $1 - p_N \sim (\log N)/N$ .

*Proof.* (a) At  $p = 0$  the endpoints have probability 0 and the middle does not. For  $p > 0$  the equation is  $S_N(u) = 1$  by (6). The coefficients of  $S_N$  are nonnegative and the linear one is 2, so  $S_N$  is strictly increasing on  $[0, \infty)$  with  $S_N(0) = 0$  and  $S_N(u) \geq 2u$ . By the intermediate value theorem there is exactly one root  $u_N \in (0, \frac{1}{2}]$ . The map  $u \mapsto p = 1/(1+u)$  is a decreasing bijection from  $[0, \infty)$  to  $(0, 1]$ . Hence  $p_N = 1/(1+u_N) \geq \frac{2}{3}$ , and the middle wins exactly when  $u > u_N$ .

(b) By Theorem 2.1,  $S_2 = 2u$ ,  $S_3 = 2u + u^2$  and  $S_4 = 2u + 2u^2 + 2u^3$ , which give the three values. For  $p_4$ , substitute  $u = (1-p)/p$  in  $S_4(u) = 1$ . For the monotonicity we compare coefficients. Going from  $N$  to  $N+1$ , one entry of the middle pair  $(a, b) = (\lfloor N/2 \rfloor, \lceil N/2 \rceil)$  grows by one and the other is unchanged. The formulas of Theorem 2.1 are symmetric in  $(a, b)$ , and every  $\binom{a-1}{\cdot}$  is nondecreasing in  $a$ . So  $W(N+1, m_{N+1}, j) \geq W(N, m_N, j)$  for every  $j$ . The coefficient of  $u^2$  is  $a + b - 2 = N - 2$ , which increases strictly. Hence  $S_{N+1}(u) > S_N(u)$  for  $u > 0$ , so  $u_{N+1} < u_N$ .

(c) We prove (c) after Theorem 3.3, from part (i) of that theorem.  $\square$

In the tables of the problem, the middle and the endpoints of row  $N+1$  are level at  $p = p_N$ . The least value is  $p_2 = \frac{2}{3}$  for the odd rows and  $p_3 = 1/\sqrt{2}$  for the even rows after the second (which is 1, 1 for every  $p$ ). There is no greatest value, since  $p_N \uparrow 1$ . The tenth row has  $p_9 = 0.82829\dots$ , just below  $\frac{5}{6}$ , so its middle and endpoints are nearly level in the third histogram of the problem (Figure 1 and Table 1).

### 3.1 A Bessel bound at every $N$

The heuristic above replaced the number  $\binom{a-1}{r}$  of ways to split  $a$  letters into  $r+1$  runs by  $a^r/r!$ . After this change the run count is exactly the power series of  $I_0$  and  $I_1$ . The next lemma controls the error of this change.

| $N$ | $p_N$      | $N$ | $p_N$      | $N$ | $p_N$      | $N$ | $p_N$      |
|-----|------------|-----|------------|-----|------------|-----|------------|
| 2   | 0.66666667 | 6   | 0.78871211 | 10  | 0.83840411 | 50  | 0.94200405 |
| 3   | 0.70710678 | 7   | 0.80361731 | 11  | 0.84652725 | 100 | 0.96496633 |
| 4   | 0.74487450 | 8   | 0.81759938 | 12  | 0.85426060 | 200 | 0.97939018 |
| 5   | 0.76759188 | 9   | 0.82829163 | 20  | 0.89293837 | 400 | 0.98812464 |

Table 1: The value  $p_N$  at which the middle and endpoint bins of row  $N + 1$  are equally likely.

**Lemma 3.2** (clipped products). (a) If  $t_1, \dots, t_r \geq 0$  and  $(v)_+ = \max(v, 0)$ , then  $0 \leq 1 - \prod_{k=1}^r (1 - t_k)_+ \leq \sum_{k=1}^r t_k$ . (b) For integers  $m \geq 1$  and  $r \geq 0$ ,  $U_r(m) := \frac{r!}{m^r} \binom{m-1}{r} = \prod_{k=1}^r (1 - \frac{k}{m})_+$ , so  $0 \leq 1 - U_r(m) \leq \frac{r(r+1)}{2m}$ . (c) For  $x \geq 0$ ,

$$\sum_{r \geq 0} \frac{r(r+1)x^{2r}}{(r!)^2} = x^2 I_0(2x) + x I_1(2x),$$

$$\sum_{r \geq 0} \frac{r(r+1)x^{2r+1}}{r!(r+1)!} = x^2 I_1(2x), \quad \sum_{r \geq 0} \frac{(r+1)x^{2r+1}}{r!(r+1)!} = x I_0(2x).$$

*Proof.* (a) Every factor lies in  $[0, 1]$ , so the product is at most 1. If some  $t_k \geq 1$  the product is 0 and the sum is at least 1. Otherwise  $\prod_k (1 - t_k) \geq 1 - \sum_k t_k$  by induction on  $r$ . (b) Note that  $\frac{r!}{m^r} \binom{m-1}{r} = \prod_{k=1}^r \frac{m-k}{m}$ . For  $r < m$  every factor is positive, and for  $r \geq m$  both sides vanish, the right side through the factor  $k = m$ . The bound is (a) with  $t_k = k/m$ . (c) Use the series of  $I_0(2x)$  and  $I_1(2x)$  from Section 1.2. Write  $r(r+1) = r^2 + r$  in the first sum, cancel the factors  $r$  and  $r+1$  against the factorials, and shift the index.  $\square$

**Theorem 3.3** (uniform Bessel approximation). Put  $h = N/2$  and  $F(x) = 2x(I_0(2x) + I_1(2x))$ , and recall that  $u_N = (1 - p_N)/p_N$ .

(i) For every  $N \geq 2$  and  $x > 0$ ,

$$0 \leq 1 - \frac{hS_N(x/h)}{F(x)} \leq \frac{x(x+1)}{h}. \quad (7)$$

(ii) Let  $x_N = hu_N$ , let  $x_B$  be the unique positive root of  $F(x_B) = h$ , and put  $\delta_N = x_N(x_N + 1)/h$ .

Then  $x_B \leq x_N$ , and  $x_N - x_B \leq -\frac{1}{2} \log(1 - \delta_N)$  whenever  $\delta_N < 1$ .

(iii) With  $u_B = x_B/h$  we have  $0 \leq u_N - u_B = O(L^2/N^2)$  as  $N \rightarrow \infty$ .

Part (i) holds at every  $N \geq 2$ , and Section 3.2 uses it to locate  $p_N$  at every  $N$ .

*Proof.* (i) *Step 1. The clipped factors.* Let  $a = \lfloor N/2 \rfloor$  and  $b = \lceil N/2 \rceil$ . As in Lemma 3.2(b),  $A_r = \frac{r!}{h^r} \binom{a-1}{r} = \prod_{k=1}^r (1 - \frac{h-a+k}{h})_+$ , and  $B_r$  is the same with  $b$  in place of  $a$ . Since  $a + b = 2h$  and  $h - a \in \{0, \frac{1}{2}\}$ , the  $2r$  numbers  $(h - a + k)/h$  and  $(h - b + k)/h$  are nonnegative with sum  $r(r+1)/h$ , so Lemma 3.2(a) gives  $0 \leq 1 - A_r B_r \leq r(r+1)/h$ . In the same way the deficits of  $A_{r+1} B_r$  and  $A_r B_{r+1}$  are at most  $((r+1)^2 + h - a)/h$  and  $((r+1)^2 + h - b)/h$ . Averaging cancels the parity offsets, so  $0 \leq 1 - \frac{1}{2}(A_{r+1} B_r + A_r B_{r+1}) \leq (r+1)^2/h$ .

*Step 2. Summing.* With  $u = x/h$  the run-count formula of Theorem 2.1 becomes

$$S_N(u) = 2u \left[ \sum_{r \geq 0} \frac{x^{2r}}{(r!)^2} A_r B_r + \sum_{r \geq 0} \frac{x^{2r+1}}{r!(r+1)!} \frac{A_{r+1} B_r + A_r B_{r+1}}{2} \right].$$

Without the factors  $A_r, B_r$  the bracket is  $I_0(2x) + I_1(2x)$  and the right side is  $F(x)/h$ . By Step 1 and Lemma 3.2(c),  $F(x)/h - S_N(u)$  lies between 0 and  $2u/h$  times  $\sum_r r(r+1) \frac{x^{2r}}{(r!)^2} + \sum_r (r+1)^2 \frac{x^{2r+1}}{r!(r+1)!} = x(x+1)(I_0(2x) + I_1(2x))$ . Dividing by  $F(x)/h = 2u(I_0(2x) + I_1(2x))$  proves (i). This covers every  $r$ , also those beyond the degree of the polynomial, where the clipped products vanish and Lemma 3.2(a) still applies.

(ii) Differentiating the series term by term gives  $F' = 2F + 2I_0(2x)$ . So  $F$  increases from 0 to  $\infty$ ,  $x_B$  is unique, and  $(\log F)' \geq 2$ . At  $x = x_N$  we have  $hS_N(u_N) = h$ , so (i) gives  $h \leq F(x_N)$ , hence  $x_B \leq x_N$ , and  $F(x_N) \leq h/(1 - \delta_N)$  when  $\delta_N < 1$ . Integrating  $(\log F)' \geq 2$  from  $x_B$  to  $x_N$  gives  $2(x_N - x_B) \leq \log(F(x_N)/h) \leq -\log(1 - \delta_N)$ .

*Proof of Theorem 3.1(c).* We use only part (i). Note that  $x^{2r}/(r!)^2 \leq (2x)^{2r}/(2r)!$  and  $x^{2r+1}/(r!(r+1)!) \leq (2x)^{2r+1}/(2r+1)!$  for  $x \geq 0$ , since  $\binom{2r}{r} \leq 4^r$  and  $\binom{2r+1}{r} \leq 2^{2r+1}$ . So  $I_0(2x) + I_1(2x) \leq e^{2x}$  and  $F(x) \leq 2xe^{2x}$ . Fix  $\theta \in (0, 1)$  and put  $x_{\pm} = (1 \pm \theta)L/2$ . Then  $F(x_-) \leq (1 - \theta)LN^{1-\theta} < h$  for large  $N$ , so  $hS_N(x_-/h) < h$  by (i), and  $x_- < x_N$  since  $S_N$  increases. On the other side  $F(x_+) \geq 2x_+I_0(2x_+)$ , which is at least a constant times  $\sqrt{L}N^{1+\theta}$  for large  $N$  by the large-argument form of  $I_0$ , while  $x_+(x_++1)/h \rightarrow 0$ . So  $hS_N(x_+/h) \geq F(x_+)(1 - x_+(x_++1)/h) > h$  for large  $N$ , and  $x_N < x_+$ . Hence  $Nu_N = 2x_N \sim L$ , so  $u_N \rightarrow 0$  and  $z_N = Nu_N/(1 + u_N) \sim L$ , which is (c).

(iii) By Theorem 3.1(c),  $x_N \sim L/2$ . So  $\delta_N = O(L^2/N)$ , and (ii) gives  $x_N - x_B = O(L^2/N)$ . Divide by  $h$ .  $\square$

### 3.2 The crossing at every $N$

We measure the crossing by  $z_N = N(1 - p_N) = Nu_N/(1 + u_N)$ , the value of  $T$  at  $p = p_N$ . Let  $\psi(z) = z + \frac{1}{2} \log z$  and  $c_0 = \frac{1}{2} \log(\pi/8) = -0.46735\dots$ , and let  $\zeta_N$  be the positive root of

$$\psi(\zeta_N) = L + c_0, \quad \text{that is,} \quad 8\zeta_N e^{2\zeta_N} = \pi N^2 \quad \text{or} \quad \zeta_N = \frac{1}{2} W_0(\pi N^2/4), \quad (8)$$

with  $W_0$  the principal branch of the Lambert function. This is the heuristic equation from the start of the section with  $w$  replaced by  $\zeta$ . Since  $\zeta e^{2\zeta}$  increases,  $\zeta_N$  increases with  $N$ . Also  $\zeta_N \leq L$ , since  $\psi(L) \geq L + c_0$  when  $L \geq \pi/8$ . Finally let  $\varepsilon_N = \zeta_N(\zeta_N + 1)/N + 1/(16\zeta_N^2)$ .

**Theorem 3.4** (the crossing at every  $N$ ). *For every  $N \geq 2$ ,*

$$\zeta_N + \frac{1}{8\zeta_N} - \varepsilon_N < z_N < \zeta_N + \frac{1}{8\zeta_N}.$$

The width  $\varepsilon_N$  tends to 0, since  $\zeta_N \leq L$  and  $\zeta_N \rightarrow \infty$ . It is 0.440, 0.163, 0.0387 and 0.00778 at  $N = 10, 10^2, 10^3, 10^4$  (Table 2).

The two terms  $\zeta_N$  and  $1/(8\zeta_N)$  come from the following heuristic. Let  $\Phi(w) = F(w/2) = w(I_0(w) + I_1(w))$  and  $\mathcal{E}(z) = \sqrt{\pi z/2} e^{-z}(I_0(z) + I_1(z))$ , which tends to 1 as  $z \rightarrow \infty$ . Put  $w_N = Nu_N$  and  $\Lambda_N = 2\Phi(w_N)/N$ . At the crossing, (7) and (9) below give  $\psi(w_N) + \log \mathcal{E}(w_N) = L + c_0 + \log \Lambda_N$  with  $0 \leq \log \Lambda_N \leq -\log(1 - w_N(w_N + 2)/(2N))$ . With  $\mathcal{E} = \Lambda_N = 1$  this would say  $w_N = \zeta_N$ . Since  $\log \mathcal{E}(w) = -1/(8w) + O(w^{-2})$  and  $z_N = w_N + O(w_N^2/N)$ , it suggests  $z_N = \zeta_N + 1/(8\zeta_N) + O(\zeta_N^{-2} + \zeta_N^2/N)$ . The theorem makes this error explicit and one-sided. Its proof uses two lemmas. Lemma 3.5 turns a comparison of  $z_N$  with a test value into a sign condition, and Lemma 3.6 bounds  $\mathcal{E}$  with explicit constants.

**Lemma 3.5** (root bracket). *Let  $N \geq 2$  and  $w > 0$ . Then*

$$\log \Phi(w) - \log \frac{N}{2} = \psi(w) - \psi(\zeta_N) + \log \mathcal{E}(w). \quad (9)$$

(a) If  $\Phi(w) \leq N/2$ , then  $Nw/(N+w) \leq z_N$ , strictly if  $\Phi(w) < N/2$ . (b) If  $\Phi(w)(1 - \frac{w(w+2)}{2N}) > N/2$ , then  $z_N < Nw/(N+w)$ .

*Proof.* Note that  $\log \Phi(w) = \psi(w) + \frac{1}{2} \log \frac{2}{\pi} + \log \mathcal{E}(w)$  and  $\log \frac{N}{2} - \psi(\zeta_N) = -\log 2 - c_0 = \frac{1}{2} \log \frac{2}{\pi}$ , which gives (9). Now apply (7) with  $x = w/2$ . Then  $F(x) = \Phi(w)$  and  $x(x+1)/h = w(w+2)/(2N)$ , so

$$\Phi(w) \left(1 - \frac{w(w+2)}{2N}\right) \leq \frac{N}{2} S_N\left(\frac{w}{N}\right) \leq \Phi(w).$$

(a) The hypothesis gives  $S_N(w/N) \leq 1 = S_N(u_N)$ , strictly if  $\Phi(w) < N/2$ . Since  $S_N$  is strictly increasing,  $w/N \leq u_N$ , strictly in that case. The map  $v \mapsto Nv/(1+v)$  increases and sends  $w/N$  to  $Nw/(N+w)$  and  $u_N$  to  $z_N$ . (b) Now  $S_N(w/N) > 1$ , so  $w/N > u_N$ .  $\square$

**Lemma 3.6** (Bessel bounds). *For every  $z > 0$ ,*

$$1 - \frac{1}{8z} - \frac{3}{128z^2} - \frac{45}{512z^3} \leq \mathcal{E}(z) \leq 1 - \frac{1}{8z} - \frac{3}{128z^2} + \frac{15}{512z^3},$$

and  $\mathcal{E}(z) \leq 1$ . In particular  $\mathcal{E}(z) \leq 1 - \frac{1}{8z}$  for  $z \geq \frac{5}{4}$ .

The lemma is the large-argument expansion of  $I_0 + I_1$  with explicit errors. We prove it in Appendix A. By [21, Eq. 10.32.3] and a substitution,  $\mathcal{E}(z) = \pi^{-1/2} \int_0^{2z} e^{-v} v^{-1/2} \sqrt{1 - v/(2z)} dv$ . We bound  $\sqrt{1 - y}$  above and below by cubics that share its Taylor terms up to  $y^2$ , extend the integral to  $\infty$ , and use  $\Gamma(k + \frac{1}{2})/\Gamma(\frac{1}{2}) = 1, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{3}{4}, \frac{15}{8}$  for  $k = 0, 1, 2, 3$ .

*Proof of Theorem 3.4. Step 1. The split at  $N = 175$ .* By (8),  $N = \sqrt{8\zeta_N/\pi} e^{\zeta_N}$ , and the right side increases in  $\zeta_N$ . Since  $\sqrt{32/\pi} e^4 = 174.25\dots$ , we have  $\zeta_N \geq 4$  exactly when  $N \geq 175$ . Write  $\zeta = \zeta_N$  and  $U = \zeta + \frac{1}{8\zeta}$ .

*Step 2. The upper bound for  $N \geq 175$ .* We apply Lemma 3.5(b) at  $W = NU/(N - U)$ , for which  $NW/(N + W) = U$ . By (9) it suffices that  $G_U = \psi(W) - \psi(\zeta) + \log \mathcal{E}(W) + \log(1 - W(W + 2)/(2N)) > 0$ . Expanding each term with Lemma 3.6 gives  $G_U \geq \frac{1}{32\zeta^2} + \frac{\zeta(\zeta-1)}{2N} + O(\zeta^{-3} + N^{-1} + \zeta^4 N^{-2})$ , and Appendix A makes every term explicit for  $\zeta \geq 4$ .

*Step 3. The lower bound for  $N \geq 175$ .* We apply Lemma 3.5(a) at  $W' = NU'/(N - U')$  with  $U' = U - \varepsilon_N$ . It suffices that  $G_{U'} = \psi(W') - \psi(\zeta) + \log \mathcal{E}(W') < 0$ , and we get  $G_{U'} \leq -\frac{3}{128\zeta^2} - \frac{\zeta}{N} + O(\zeta^{-3} + N^{-1} + \zeta^4 N^{-2})$ , again with explicit constants for every  $\zeta \geq 4$  in Appendix A. The term  $-\zeta/N$  is why  $\varepsilon_N$  contains  $\zeta(\zeta + 1)/N$ .

*Step 4.  $2 \leq N \leq 174$ , by certificates.* Let  $d = 10^9$  and let  $c < c'$  be integers with  $c' = c + 1$  ( $c' = c + 2$  at  $N = 2$ , where  $u_2 = \frac{1}{2}$  is a grid point). The sign of  $S_N(c/d) - 1$  is the sign of  $n_N(m_N) - d^{N-1}$ , where  $n_N(m_N) = d^{N-1} S_N(c/d)$  is the integer of Remark 2.3 at  $(\alpha, \beta) = (d, c)$  (Appendix A.3). We computed these integers at  $c$  and  $c'$  by two exact methods, the run-count sum of Theorem 2.1 and the recursion (3) with integer weights  $d, c$  in place of  $p, q$ . They agreed for every  $N \leq 174$  and gave  $c/d < u_N < c'/d$ , so  $z(c/d) < z_N < z(c'/d)$  with  $z(u) = Nu/(1 + u)$ . We then checked  $\zeta_N + \frac{1}{8\zeta_N} - \varepsilon_N < z(c/d)$  and  $z(c'/d) < \zeta_N + \frac{1}{8\zeta_N}$  in 60-digit decimal arithmetic, with  $\zeta_N$  in a bracket of width  $10^{-45}$ . We certified this bracket by the sign of  $\psi(\zeta) - L - c_0$ , which is the sign of  $8\zeta e^{2\zeta} - \pi N^2$ , at both of its ends, using a correctly rounded logarithm. The smallest margins are 0.033193 (upper) and 0.085591 (lower), both at  $N = 174$ . Rounding cannot change these comparisons. Put  $g_1(\zeta) = \zeta + \frac{1}{8\zeta}$  and  $g_2(\zeta) = g_1(\zeta) - \frac{\zeta(\zeta+1)}{N} - \frac{1}{16\zeta^2}$ . For  $\frac{1}{2} \leq \zeta \leq L + 1$  and  $N \geq 2$  we have  $|g'_1|, |g'_2| \leq 5$ , and  $\frac{1}{2} < \zeta_2 \leq \zeta_N \leq L$ . So  $g_1$  and  $g_2$  vary by at most  $5 \cdot 10^{-45}$  on the bracket, and the decimal evaluation adds at most  $10^{-50}$ . Both are far below the margin 0.03. The Lean proof checks the same comparisons with rational bounds on  $\zeta_N$  and  $\pi$ . As a cross-check, the

certificates also pass for  $N \leq 1000$ , by both methods up to 400 and by the run-count sum after that.  $\square$

| $N$    | $z_N$          | $\zeta_N$    | $z_N - \zeta_N - \frac{1}{8\zeta_N}$ | $-\varepsilon_N$ | $R_N$     |
|--------|----------------|--------------|--------------------------------------|------------------|-----------|
| 2      | 0.666666666667 | 0.5368290974 | -0.1030112                           | -0.62938         | +0.050643 |
| 10     | 1.615958871376 | 1.6001732978 | -0.0623310                           | -0.44048         | -0.056660 |
| 100    | 3.503367368092 | 3.5100055489 | -0.0422507                           | -0.16337         | -0.043265 |
| 174    | 3.996779704730 | 3.9987131703 | -0.0331935                           | -0.11878         | -0.033450 |
| 175    | 4.001967989170 | 4.0038072816 | -0.0330596                           | -0.11838         | -0.033304 |
| 1000   | 5.590351166975 | 5.5807388611 | -0.0127862                           | -0.03873         | -0.011887 |
| $10^4$ | 7.734265514999 | 7.7210118331 | -0.0029359                           | -0.00778         | -0.002051 |

Table 2: The crossing against Theorem 3.4, and the remainder  $R_N$  of (12). We computed  $z_N$  by run-count bisection in 60-digit decimal arithmetic and by a floating-point dynamic program, which agree to the digits shown.

The bracket involves  $\zeta_N$ . The next corollary states it for  $p_N$  and expands it in  $L = \log N$ .

**Corollary 3.7.** Put  $\nu_N = L - \frac{1}{2} \log L + c_0$ .

(a) For every  $N \geq 2$ ,  $1 - (\zeta_N + \frac{1}{8\zeta_N})/N < p_N < 1 - (\zeta_N + \frac{1}{8\zeta_N} - \varepsilon_N)/N$ .

(b) For every  $N \geq 2$ ,  $\nu_N \leq \zeta_N \leq \nu_N + \frac{\log L - 2c_0}{4\nu_N}$  and

$$-\varepsilon_N < z_N - \nu_N < \frac{\log L - 2c_0 + \frac{1}{2}}{4\nu_N}. \quad (10)$$

In particular  $z_N = L - \frac{1}{2} \log L + c_0 + O(\log L/L)$  as  $N \rightarrow \infty$ .

(c) As  $N \rightarrow \infty$ ,

$$z_N = \nu_N + \frac{\frac{1}{4} \log L - \frac{1}{2} c_0 + \frac{1}{8}}{L} + O\left(\frac{(\log L)^2}{L^2}\right). \quad (11)$$

(d) (Computer-assisted.)  $z_N > \zeta_N$  for every  $N \geq 2774$ .

*Proof.* (a) is Theorem 3.4 with  $p_N = 1 - z_N/N$ .

(b) By (8),  $\zeta_N = L + c_0 - \frac{1}{2} \log \zeta_N$ . Since  $\zeta_N \leq L$ , this gives  $\zeta_N \geq \nu_N$ , and  $\nu_N > 0$  since it increases in  $N$  and  $\nu_2 = 0.41$ . Also  $\log y \leq y - 1$  gives  $\zeta_N - \nu_N = \frac{1}{2} \log(L/\zeta_N) \leq (L - \zeta_N)/(2\zeta_N)$ , and  $L - \zeta_N = \frac{1}{2} \log \zeta_N - c_0 \leq \frac{1}{2} \log L - c_0$ . Hence  $\zeta_N - \nu_N \leq (\log L - 2c_0)/(4\nu_N)$ . For  $z_N$ , add Theorem 3.4 and  $0 < \frac{1}{8\zeta_N} \leq \frac{1}{8\nu_N}$ . The last claim follows since  $\varepsilon_N = O(L^2/N + L^{-2})$ .

(c) Put  $\eta = \zeta_N - \nu_N = \frac{1}{2} \log(L/\zeta_N)$ . By (b),  $L - \zeta_N = \frac{1}{2} \log L - c_0 + O(\log L/L)$ , so  $\eta = \frac{L - \zeta_N}{2L} + O\left(\frac{(\log L)^2}{L^2}\right) = \frac{\frac{1}{4} \log L - \frac{1}{2} c_0}{L} + O\left(\frac{(\log L)^2}{L^2}\right)$ . Also  $\frac{1}{8\zeta_N} = \frac{1}{8L} + O\left(\frac{\log L}{L^2}\right)$  and  $\varepsilon_N = O(L^2/N + L^{-2})$ , and Theorem 3.4 gives (c).

(d) By Theorem 3.4,  $z_N - \zeta_N > \frac{1}{8\zeta_N} - \varepsilon_N$ , which is positive when  $f(\zeta_N) > 1$ , where  $f(\zeta) = n(\zeta)(\frac{1}{8\zeta} - \frac{1}{16\zeta^2})/(\zeta(\zeta + 1))$  and  $n(\zeta) = \sqrt{8\zeta/\pi} e^\zeta$ , so that  $n(\zeta_N) = N$ . The logarithmic derivative of  $f$  is  $1 + \frac{1}{2\zeta} - \frac{2}{\zeta} + \frac{1}{2\zeta^2 - \zeta} - \frac{1}{\zeta + 1} > 1 - \frac{3}{2\zeta} - \frac{1}{\zeta + 1} > 0$  for  $\zeta \geq 3$ . Since  $\zeta_N$  increases with  $N$ , once  $f(\zeta_N) > 1$  it stays above 1. This step is computer-assisted. In 60-digit decimal arithmetic, with  $\zeta_N$  bracketed within  $10^{-45}$  as in Step 4 above, we found  $f(\zeta_{2774}) - 1 = 2.1 \times 10^{-4}$ , and the sign holds on the whole bracket. Since  $\zeta_{2774} > 3$ , this proves (d). The condition fails at  $N = 2773$ .  $\square$

The heuristic suggests that  $\psi(z_N) \approx L + c_0 + 1/(8z_N)$ . The next proposition proves this at every  $N$  with an explicit remainder.

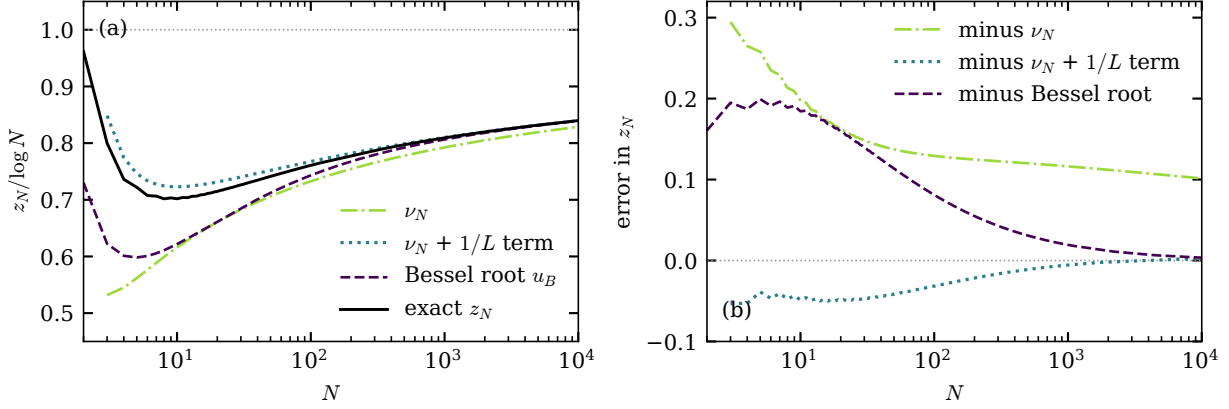


Figure 2: (a) The scaled crossing  $z_N / \log N$  (solid) and the same quantity from the Bessel root  $u_B$  of Theorem 3.3 (dashed), from  $\nu_N$  of (10) (through the constant) and from  $\nu_N + (\frac{1}{4} \log L - \frac{1}{2} c_0 + \frac{1}{8}) / L$  of (11) (with the  $1/L$  term). The ratio tends to 1 very slowly. (b) The exact  $z_N$  minus each approximation.

**Proposition 3.8** (the crossing equation). *For every  $N \geq 2$ ,*

$$z_N + \frac{1}{2} \log z_N = L + c_0 + \frac{1}{8z_N} + R_N, \quad -\frac{z_N^2 + z_N}{N} \leq R_N \leq \frac{1}{16z_N^2}. \quad (12)$$

Moreover  $L/2 \leq z_N \leq L$ , so  $|R_N| \leq \frac{1}{4L^2} + \frac{L^2+L}{N}$  for every  $N \geq 2$ .

We prove Proposition 3.8 in Appendix A. The proof writes  $R_N$  exactly, using (7) and (9) at  $w = w_N$  (formula (41)). For  $N \geq 175$ , Lemma 3.6 puts the Bessel part of this formula between 0 and  $0.0559/z_N^2$ , and the other terms lie between  $-(z_N^2 + z_N)/N$  and 0. For  $N \leq 174$  the proof uses the same certificates as Theorem 3.4.

*Remark 3.9* (the sign of  $z_N - \zeta_N$ , computer-assisted). We have  $z_N > \zeta_N$  for  $N \leq 15$ ,  $z_N < \zeta_N$  for  $16 \leq N \leq 218$ , and  $z_N > \zeta_N$  for every  $N \geq 219$ . For  $N \leq 1000$  the certificates decide the sign, since  $\zeta_N$  never lies in  $[z(c/d), z(c'/d)]$ . The smallest distance is  $1.66 \times 10^{-5}$ , at  $N = 218$ . Both exact methods cover  $N \leq 400$ , and the run-count sum alone covers the rest. For  $1001 \leq N \leq 2773$  we checked  $S_N(v) < 1$  in exact integers from the run-count sum, at a rational  $v$  above  $\zeta_N/(N - \zeta_N)$  by at least  $1.2 \times 10^{-11}$ , where  $z(\zeta_N/(N - \zeta_N)) = \zeta_N$ . These integers were cross-checked by floating-point run-count and dynamic-program sign tests for every  $N \leq 3000$ , and by the integer recursion at  $N = 401, 1000, 1008, 2000, 2773$ . For  $N \geq 2774$  the sign is Corollary 3.7(d).

The ratios  $u_B/u_N$  of the Bessel root of Theorem 3.3 to the true odds are 0.9761, 0.9864, 0.9924 at  $N = 100, 200, 400$  and 0.99579, 0.99769, 0.99874 at  $N = 800, 1600, 3200$ , in line with the relative error  $O(L^2/N)$  of Theorem 3.3. Figure 2 compares the exact crossing with the expansions of Corollary 3.7 up to  $N = 10^4$ .

## 4 The crossing of every bin

This section finds, for each bin  $k$ , the value of  $p$  at which bin  $k$  is exactly as likely as an endpoint. Figure 3 shows it for three values of  $N$ . The crossing  $1 - p_{a, N-a}$  decreases as the bin moves in from the edge, from order  $N^{-1/2}$  next to the edge to order  $(\log N)/N$  in the middle.

## 4.1 Ordering the crossings

Let  $a, b \geq 1$  be integers,  $N = a + b$  and  $p > 0$ , and recall that  $S_{a,b}(u) = P_N(a)/P_N(0)$  with  $u = (1 - p)/p$ . Theorem 2.1 and  $\binom{m-1}{r+1} = \frac{m-1-r}{r+1} \binom{m-1}{r}$  for  $m = a, b$  give

$$S_{a,b}(u) = \sum_{r \geq 0} \binom{a-1}{r} \binom{b-1}{r} \left( 2u^{2r+1} + \frac{N-2-2r}{r+1} u^{2r+2} \right). \quad (13)$$

Its coefficients are nonnegative, as  $N - 2 - 2r \geq |b - a|$  for  $r < \min(a, b)$ , and the linear one is 2. So there is a unique  $u_{a,b} > 0$  with  $S_{a,b}(u_{a,b}) = 1$ , and  $p_{a,b} = 1/(1 + u_{a,b})$ . As  $S_{a,b}(u) \geq 2u$ , we have  $u_{a,b} \leq \frac{1}{2}$  and  $p_{a,b} \in [\frac{2}{3}, 1)$ , with  $p_{a,b} = \frac{2}{3}$  only for  $a = b = 1$ .

**Proposition 4.1** (ordering the crossings). *If  $a < b - 1$ , then*

$$u_{a+1,b-1} < u_{a,b}, \quad p_{a+1,b-1} > p_{a,b}.$$

*Also  $p_{a,b+1} > p_{a,b}$  for all positive  $a, b$ . Moreover  $S_{a+1,b-1} \geq S_{a,b}$  and  $S_{a,b+1} \geq S_{a,b}$  coefficientwise, with at least one strict coefficient.*

So a bin closer to the middle, or in a longer row, needs a larger  $p$  to fall to the endpoint height.

*Proof.* For fixed  $N$  and  $r \leq a-1$ ,  $\binom{a-1}{r} \binom{b-1}{r} = (r!)^{-2} \prod_{j=0}^{r-1} (a-1-j)(b-1-j)$ , a product of positive factors. Each factor grows when  $(a, b)$  becomes  $(a+1, b-1)$ , by  $(a-j)(b-2-j) - (a-1-j)(b-1-j) = b - a - 1 > 0$ . The even multiplier  $(N - 2 - 2r)/(r + 1)$  is unchanged, and it is nonnegative where either product is nonzero, since then  $r \leq a$  and  $N - 2 - 2r \geq b - a - 2 \geq 0$ . New summands are nonnegative, and the cubic coefficient grows strictly, from  $2(a-1)(b-1)$  to  $2a(b-2)$ . Increasing  $b$  with  $a$  fixed increases the binomial coefficients of Theorem 2.1, and the quadratic coefficient  $N - 2$  strictly. A polynomial with nonnegative coefficients that dominates another coefficientwise, strictly somewhere, is strictly larger at every  $u > 0$ , so its root is smaller.  $\square$

The ordering of the bin heights below also follows from the interior log-concavity of Dekking and Kong [10, Proposition 4.3]. We use the coefficients because they also give the strict gap in the next proposition. The first half of that proposition is already in their work. By [10, Theorem 4.1], for  $N \geq 4$  and  $0 < p < 1$  the row is trimodal exactly when  $P_N(0) > P_N(1)$ , since  $P_N(1) < P_N(2)$  here, and their Example 4.2 with  $a = b = q$  and the stationary start gives  $P_N(1)/P_N(0) = 2u + (N-2)u^2$ , which is  $S_{1,N-1}(u)$ . The next proposition adds the comparison  $p_N > p_N^{\text{adj}}$  for  $N \geq 4$  and the global extrema at  $p_N$ .

**Proposition 4.2** (adjacent bins and global extrema). *For  $N \geq 2$  and  $0 < p < 1$ , an adjacent bin has the same probability as an endpoint precisely at*

$$p_N^{\text{adj}} = \frac{1 + \sqrt{N-1}}{2 + \sqrt{N-1}}.$$

*For  $0 < p < 1$ , the endpoints are the least likely bins if  $p < p_N^{\text{adj}}$ , bins 1 and  $N-1$  are if  $p > p_N^{\text{adj}}$ , and they tie at equality. For  $N \geq 4$ , the central crossing satisfies  $p_N > p_N^{\text{adj}}$ . At  $p = p_N$ , the middle bin and the end bins attain the global maximum and bins 1,  $N-1$  attain the global minimum. For  $N = 2, 3$ ,  $p_N = p_N^{\text{adj}}$  and every bin ties at the crossing.*

So at the central crossing the row has the shape of a W. It is high at the two ends and in the middle, and lowest next to the ends.

*Proof.* By (13),  $S_{1,N-1}(u) = 2u + (N-2)u^2$ , with positive root  $u^{\text{adj}} = 1/(1 + \sqrt{N-1})$ . This gives  $p_N^{\text{adj}}$  and the sign change. For  $0 < p < 1$  we have  $P_N(k) = P_N(0)S_{k,N-k}(u)$  with  $P_N(0) > 0$ , so if  $1 \leq k < N-k-1$  Proposition 4.1 gives  $P_N(k) < P_N(k+1)$ . By symmetry the middle is the largest interior bin and bins  $1, N-1$  are the smallest, which gives the claims about the least likely bins. For  $N \geq 4$  the cubic coefficient  $2(\lfloor N/2 \rfloor - 1)(\lceil N/2 \rceil - 1)$  of  $S_N$  is positive, so  $2u_N + (N-2)u_N^2 < S_N(u_N) = 1$ , hence  $u_N < u^{\text{adj}}$  and  $p_N > p_N^{\text{adj}}$ . At  $p_N$  the middle ties with the endpoints, which gives the global maximum, and bins  $1, N-1$  are below the endpoints, which gives the global minimum. For  $N = 2, 3$  we have  $S_N = S_{1,N-1}$ , and symmetry gives the ties.  $\square$

So  $1 - p_N^{\text{adj}} \sim N^{-1/2}$ , much larger than  $1 - p_N \sim (\log N)/N$ . Away from the ends, the single letter + of bin 1 needs two switches, so  $S_{1,N-1} \approx Nu^2$  reaches 1 only at  $u \approx N^{-1/2}$ . (At  $p = 0$  and  $p = 1$  there are also ties between bins of probability 0.)

## 4.2 A Bessel estimate uniform in the bin

Bin  $a$  has about  $(a^r/r!)(b^r/r!)$  words with  $r$  runs of each letter, each of weight about  $u^{2r}$ . The sum depends only on  $abu^2$ , so a bin near the edge acts like the middle of a shorter row with  $\sqrt{ab}$  in place of  $N/2$ . Put

$$s = \sqrt{ab}, \quad A = \frac{ab}{a+b}, \quad c = \frac{a+b}{2\sqrt{ab}}, \quad \eta = \frac{1}{c}, \quad x = su, \quad J_c(x) = I_0(2x) + cI_1(2x),$$

and  $\widehat{S}_{a,b}(u) = 2uJ_c(su)$ . Here  $c \geq 1$  and  $0 < \eta \leq 1$ , with  $\eta = 1$  exactly when  $a = b$ .

**Theorem 4.3** (uniform estimate for every bin). *For all positive integers  $a, b$  and all  $u > 0$ ,*

$$0 \leq 1 - \frac{S_{a,b}(u)}{\widehat{S}_{a,b}(u)} \leq \frac{(a+b)u^2}{2} + u = \frac{x^2}{2A} + \frac{x}{s}. \quad (14)$$

*In particular, for fixed  $N$  and  $u$  the bound does not depend on the bin. The inequality still holds when the right side exceeds 1, but then it gives no lower bound on  $S_{a,b}$ .*

When  $u$  is about  $L/N$ , the bound is  $O(L^2/N)$  for every bin at once. The proof follows that of Theorem 3.3(i), with the two letters weighted by  $a$  and  $b$ .

*Proof.* Let  $U_r = U_r(a)$  and  $V_r = U_r(b)$  as in Lemma 3.2(b), and note that  $1/a + 1/b = 1/A$ . Lemma 3.2(a), applied to the  $2r$  clipped factors of  $U_r V_r$ , gives

$$0 \leq 1 - U_r V_r \leq \frac{r(r+1)}{2A}. \quad (15)$$

Lemma 3.2(a) gives  $1 - U_{r+1} V_r \leq \frac{(r+1)(r+2)}{2a} + \frac{r(r+1)}{2b}$ , and the same with  $a$  and  $b$  exchanged for  $U_r V_{r+1}$ . Averaging with weights  $a$  and  $b$ , the weighted average  $E_r = (aU_{r+1} V_r + bU_r V_{r+1})/(a+b)$  satisfies

$$\begin{aligned} 0 \leq 1 - E_r &\leq \frac{(r+1)(r+2)}{a+b} + \frac{r(r+1)}{2(a+b)} \left( \frac{a}{b} + \frac{b}{a} \right) \\ &= \frac{r(r+1)}{2A} + \frac{2(r+1)}{a+b}. \end{aligned} \quad (16)$$

Since  $\binom{a-1}{r} = a^r U_r / r!$ , (13) becomes

$$S_{a,b}(u) = 2u \left[ \sum_{r \geq 0} \frac{x^{2r}}{(r!)^2} U_r V_r + c \sum_{r \geq 0} \frac{x^{2r+1}}{r!(r+1)!} E_r \right], \quad (17)$$

and dropping  $U_r V_r$  and  $E_r$  gives  $\widehat{S}_{a,b}(u)$ . So by Lemma 3.2(c), with  $I_j = I_j(2x)$ ,  $(\widehat{S}_{a,b} - S_{a,b})/(2u)$  lies between 0 and

$$\frac{1}{2A}(x^2 I_0 + x I_1 + c x^2 I_1) + \frac{2c x I_0}{a+b} = \left( \frac{x^2}{2A} + \frac{x}{s} \right) J_c(x),$$

since  $c/s = 1/(2A)$  and  $2c/(a+b) = 1/s$ . Divide by  $\widehat{S}_{a,b}/(2u) = J_c(x)$ .  $\square$

To turn this into a bound on the crossing, let  $x_{a,b} = s u_{a,b}$  and let  $x_B$  be the positive root of

$$G_\eta(x_B) = A, \quad G_\eta(x) = x \{I_1(2x) + \eta I_0(2x)\}. \quad (18)$$

Differentiating term by term gives

$$G'_\eta(x) - 2G_\eta(x) = 2x(1-\eta)\{I_0(2x) - I_1(2x)\} + \eta I_0(2x) \geq 0, \quad (19)$$

since  $I_0(2x) - I_1(2x) = \frac{1}{\pi} \int_0^\pi e^{2x \cos \theta} (1 - \cos \theta) d\theta > 0$  by [21, Eq. 10.32.3]. So  $(\log G_\eta)' \geq 2$  for  $x > 0$  and  $0 \leq \eta \leq 1$ , and  $x_B$  is unique.

**Corollary 4.4** (quantitative crossing bound). *We have  $x_{a,b} \geq x_B$ . If*

$$\delta_{a,b} = \frac{x_{a,b}^2}{2A} + \frac{x_{a,b}}{s} < 1,$$

*then*

$$0 \leq x_{a,b} - x_B \leq -\frac{1}{2} \log(1 - \delta_{a,b}). \quad (20)$$

*Proof.* Since  $c\eta = 1$  and  $2c/s = 1/A$ , we have  $\widehat{S}_{a,b}(u) = G_\eta(su)/A$ . At the crossing  $S_{a,b} = 1$ , so Theorem 4.3 gives  $A \leq G_\eta(x_{a,b}) \leq A/(1 - \delta_{a,b})$ . As  $G_\eta(x_B) = A$ , this gives  $x_{a,b} \geq x_B$ , and integrating  $(\log G_\eta)' \geq 2$  from  $x_B$  to  $x_{a,b}$  gives (20). This is the argument of Theorem 3.3(ii). For even  $N$  and  $a = b$  the two statements coincide, since then  $\eta = 1$ ,  $s = h$  and  $2G_1 = F$ .  $\square$

*Remark 4.5* (Jacobi polynomials). The Bessel forms of this paper come from the confluence of Jacobi, Laguerre and Bessel functions near the point 1. For  $a \leq b$  and  $0 \leq t < 1$ ,

$$\sum_{r \geq 0} \binom{a-1}{r} \binom{b-1}{r} t^r = {}_2F_1(1-a, 1-b; 1; t) = (1-t)^{a-1} P_{a-1}^{(0, b-a)} \left( \frac{1+t}{1-t} \right),$$

and for  $b > a$  and  $0 \leq u < 1$ ,

$$\sum_{r \geq 0} \binom{a-1}{r} \binom{b-1}{r+1} u^{2r+2} = \frac{(b-1)u^2}{a} (1-u^2)^{a-1} P_{a-1}^{(1, b-a-1)} \left( \frac{1+u^2}{1-u^2} \right).$$

Near 1, Jacobi polynomials of large degree behave like Bessel functions (Mehler–Heine [21, Eq. 18.11.5]), with expansions in modified Bessel functions uniform near 1 by Elliott [11, Section 3]. For fixed  $a$  and  $y = bu^2$ , as  $b \rightarrow \infty$ , [21, Eq. 18.7.21] turns the last sum into  $(y/a)L_{a-1}^{(1)}(-y) = H_a(y)$  of (25), and the other terms tend to 0. Temme [20, Section 4.2] also compares Jacobi with Laguerre polynomials. But Elliott’s expansions are for fixed parameters and are formal, with error bounds left to later work [11, Section 1], while here  $b - a$  can be as large as  $N - 2$ , and Theorem 4.3 gives an explicit relative error at every  $N$ .

### 4.3 Every growing distance from an edge

The Bessel root satisfies an equation of the form  $z + \frac{1}{2} \log z = \ell + C + B/z + \dots$ . The next lemma inverts such equations.

**Lemma 4.6** (inverting  $z + \frac{1}{2} \log z$ ). *Fix  $K > 0$ . There is a constant  $C_K$  with the following property. Let  $z \geq 1$  and  $\ell \geq 2$ , and suppose that  $z + \frac{1}{2} \log z = \ell + C + B/z + \omega$  with  $|C|, |B| \leq K$  and  $|\omega| \leq 1$ . Then*

$$\left| z - \ell + \frac{1}{2} \log \ell - C - \frac{\frac{1}{4} \log \ell - \frac{1}{2} C + B}{\ell} \right| \leq C_K \left( \frac{(\log \ell)^2}{\ell^2} + |\omega| \right).$$

*Proof.* Put  $w = z - \ell$ . As  $z \geq 1$ ,  $\log z \geq 0$  and  $|B/z| \leq K$ , so  $z \leq \ell + 2K + 1$  and  $|w| \leq 2K + 1 + \frac{1}{2} \log(\ell + 2K + 1) = O_K(\log \ell)$ . This proves the claim for  $\ell$  bounded in terms of  $K$ , since then both sides are  $O_K(1)$  and  $(\log \ell)^2/\ell^2$  is bounded below. For larger  $\ell$  we have  $|w| \leq \ell/2$ , so  $\log z = \log \ell + w/\ell + O((w/\ell)^2)$  and  $B/z = B/\ell + O_K(|w|/\ell^2)$ , and  $w = C - \frac{1}{2} \log \ell - w/(2\ell) + B/\ell + \omega + O_K((\log \ell)^2/\ell^2)$ . This gives first  $w = d + O_K(\log \ell/\ell + |\omega|)$  with  $d = C - \frac{1}{2} \log \ell$ , and then, putting this back into the term  $w/(2\ell)$ ,  $w = d + (B - d/2)/\ell + O_K((\log \ell)^2/\ell^2 + |\omega|)$ .  $\square$

**Theorem 4.7** (uniform crossing expansion). *Let  $1 \leq a \leq b$ , and put*

$$\ell = \log A, \quad C(\eta) = \frac{1}{2} \log(8\pi) - \log(1 + \eta), \quad B(\eta) = \frac{3 - \eta}{8(1 + \eta)}.$$

*As  $a \rightarrow \infty$ , uniformly over  $b \geq a$ ,*

$$\begin{aligned} 2\sqrt{ab} u_{a,b} &= \ell - \frac{1}{2} \log \ell + C(\eta) \\ &\quad + \frac{\frac{1}{4} \log \ell - \frac{1}{2} C(\eta) + B(\eta)}{\ell} + O \left( \frac{(\log \ell)^2}{\ell^2} + \frac{(\log a)^2}{a} \right). \end{aligned} \quad (21)$$

*That is, there are  $a_0$  and  $K'$  such that the error term is at most  $K'$  times the bracket for all  $a \geq a_0$  and all  $b \geq a$ . The same holds with  $1 - p_{a,b}$  in place of  $u_{a,b}$ .*

Here  $A = ab/(a + b)$  is half the harmonic mean of  $a$  and  $b$ . There is no condition on how  $a$  compares with  $N$ , so the theorem covers a bin at distance  $\sqrt{N}$  from the edge as well as the middle. The proof uses Corollary 4.4 to pass to the Bessel root  $x_B$ . The large-argument form of  $I_0$  and  $I_1$  then turns (18) into an equation that Lemma 4.6 solves.

*Proof.* Here  $a/2 \leq A \leq a$ ,  $s \geq a$  and  $0 < \eta \leq 1$ .

*Step 1. The crossing is at  $x_{a,b} \leq \log a$ .* At  $x = \log a$  the bound of Theorem 4.3 is at most  $2(\log a)^2/a$ , while  $\widehat{S}_{a,b} = G_\eta(x)/A \geq x I_1(2x)/a \rightarrow \infty$ , both uniformly in  $b$  (the identity  $\widehat{S}_{a,b}(u) = G_\eta(su)/A$  is in the proof of Corollary 4.4). So  $S_{a,b} > 1$  there, and since  $S_{a,b}$  increases,  $x_{a,b} \leq \log a$  for all  $a \geq a_0$  and all  $b \geq a$ . Then  $\delta_{a,b} \leq 2(\log a)^2/a$ , and Corollary 4.4 gives

$$x_{a,b} - x_B = O((\log a)^2/a). \quad (22)$$

*Step 2. The Bessel root.* Write  $z = 2x_B$ , so  $z \rightarrow \infty$  as  $A \rightarrow \infty$ , uniformly in  $\eta$ . By the large-argument form of  $I_0$  and  $I_1$  [21, Eq. 10.40.1],  $I_1(z) + \eta I_0(z) = (1 + \eta)e^z(2\pi z)^{-1/2}(1 - B(\eta)/z + O(z^{-2}))$  uniformly in  $0 \leq \eta \leq 1$ . Taking logarithms in (18) gives  $z + \frac{1}{2} \log z = \ell + C(\eta) + B(\eta)/z + O(z^{-2})$ . As  $|C(\eta)| \leq 2$  and  $0 < B(\eta) \leq \frac{3}{8}$ , Lemma 4.6 with  $K = 2$  expands  $z$ .

*Step 3. Back to the crossing.* By (22) the expansion moves to  $2x_{a,b} = 2\sqrt{ab} u_{a,b}$ . Finally  $2s(u - u/(1 + u)) \leq 2x^2/s = O((\log a)^2/a)$  at  $u = u_{a,b}$ , which gives the same expansion for  $1 - p_{a,b} = u_{a,b}/(1 + u_{a,b})$ .  $\square$

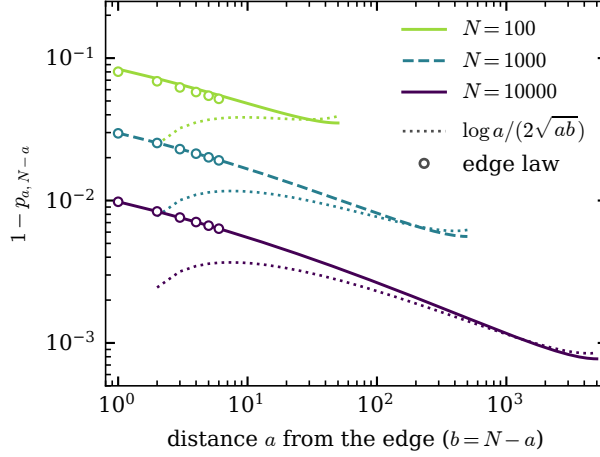


Figure 3: The crossing  $1 - p_{a, N-a}$  of each bin against its distance  $a$  from the nearer edge, for  $N = 100, 1000$  and  $10^4$ . The dotted lines are the leading law (23), and the circles are the edge law (27) for  $a \leq 6$ . The right end of each line is the central crossing  $1 - p_N$ .

Hence, uniformly in  $b$ ,

$$1 - p_{a,b} \sim \frac{\log a}{2\sqrt{ab}} \quad (a \rightarrow \infty, b \geq a). \quad (23)$$

If  $a = o(b)$ , then  $\eta \rightarrow 0$  and  $\log A = \log a + o(1)$ , so

$$2\sqrt{ab}(1 - p_{a,b}) = \log a - \frac{1}{2} \log \log a + \frac{1}{2} \log(8\pi) + o(1). \quad (24)$$

If  $a/N \rightarrow \alpha \in (0, \frac{1}{2}]$  at any rate, then

$$2\sqrt{a(N-a)}(1 - p_{a, N-a}) = \log N - \frac{1}{2} \log \log N + \log\{\alpha(1-\alpha)\} + C(2\sqrt{\alpha(1-\alpha)}) + o(1).$$

At the center,  $a = b = N/2$  gives  $A = N/4$  and  $\eta = 1$ , and changing from  $\log A$  to  $\log N$  recovers (11).

#### 4.4 Fixed bins and the Laguerre edge law

Now let  $a$  be fixed and  $b \rightarrow \infty$ . A run of letters  $+$  away from the ends needs two switches, which gives a factor  $u^2$ , and it can go in about  $b$  places. So the right variable is  $y = bu^2$ . Define

$$H_a(y) = \sum_{r=0}^{a-1} \binom{a-1}{r} \frac{y^{r+1}}{(r+1)!} = \frac{y}{a} L_{a-1}^{(1)}(-y), \quad (25)$$

with the standard Laguerre polynomial  $L_{a-1}^{(1)}$ . Let  $y_a$  be the positive root of  $H_a(y_a) = 1$  and  $c_a = \sqrt{y_a}$ . Then  $y_1 = 1$ ,  $y_2 = \sqrt{3} - 1$ , and  $y_a$  decreases strictly in  $a$ , by coefficient comparison.

**Theorem 4.8** (fixed-edge expansion). *For each fixed positive integer  $a$ , as  $b \rightarrow \infty$ ,*

$$u_{a,b} = \frac{c_a}{\sqrt{b}} - \frac{1}{b} + \frac{\gamma_a}{b^{3/2}} + O_a(b^{-2}), \quad (26)$$

where

$$\gamma_a = \frac{1 + y_a + (y_a + y_a^2/2)H_a''(y_a)/H_a'(y_a)}{2c_a}.$$

Thus the second coefficient in the odds expansion is  $-1$  for every fixed bin. For the switching probability,

$$1 - p_{a,b} = \frac{c_a}{\sqrt{b}} - \frac{1 + c_a^2}{b} + O_a(b^{-3/2}). \quad (27)$$

For bin 1, where  $y_1 = 1$  and  $H_1'' = 0$ , this gives  $u_{1,b} = b^{-1/2} - b^{-1} + b^{-3/2} + \dots$ , the expansion of the exact root  $1/(1 + \sqrt{b})$  of Proposition 4.2.

*Proof.* Put  $\theta = b^{-1/2}$ ,  $y = bu^2$  and  $V_r = U_r(b)$ . For  $b \geq a$ , (13) reads

$$\begin{aligned} S_{a,b}(u) &= 2\sqrt{y/b} \sum_r \binom{a-1}{r} \frac{y^r}{r!} V_r \\ &\quad + \frac{y}{b} \sum_r \binom{a-1}{r+1} \frac{y^r}{r!} V_r + y \sum_r \binom{a-1}{r} \frac{y^r}{(r+1)!} V_{r+1}. \end{aligned} \quad (28)$$

These sums have at most  $a$  terms, and with  $V_r = 1$  they are  $H_a'(y)$ ,  $H_a''(y)$  and  $H_a(y)$ . Expanding  $V_r = 1 - r(r+1)/(2b) + O_a(b^{-2})$  and using  $\sum_r (r+1)(r+2) \binom{a-1}{r} \frac{y^{r+1}}{(r+1)!} = y^2 H_a''(y) + 2y H_a'(y)$  gives, uniformly near  $y = y_a$ ,

$$\begin{aligned} S_{a,b}(u) &= H_a(y) + 2\sqrt{y} H_a'(y)\theta \\ &\quad + \{(y - y^2/2)H_a''(y) - yH_a'(y)\}\theta^2 + O_a(\theta^3). \end{aligned} \quad (29)$$

With  $b = \theta^{-2}$  the right side of (28) is analytic in  $(\theta, y)$  near  $(0, y_a)$ , and  $H_a'(y_a) > 0$ . So the implicit-function theorem gives an analytic solution  $y(\theta) = y_a + d_1\theta + d_2\theta^2 + O_a(\theta^3)$  of  $S_{a,b} = 1$ , and by the uniqueness of the crossing it is the value of  $y$  at  $u = u_{a,b}$ . Matching coefficients in (29) gives  $d_1 = -2c_a$  and  $d_2 = 2 + y_a + (y_a + y_a^2/2)H_a''(y_a)/H_a'(y_a)$ . Expanding  $u = \theta\sqrt{y}$  and then  $u/(1+u)$  proves both expansions.  $\square$

The next theorem shows that for large  $a$  the Laguerre root  $y_a$  obeys the growing-distance law (24).

**Theorem 4.9** (matching the edge and Bessel regimes). *For every positive integer  $a$  and every  $x > 0$ ,*

$$0 \leq 1 - \frac{aH_a(x^2/a)}{xI_1(2x)} \leq \frac{x^2}{2a}. \quad (30)$$

Consequently, with  $\ell = \log a$  and  $C(0) = \frac{1}{2} \log(8\pi)$  as in Theorem 4.7, as  $a \rightarrow \infty$ ,

$$\begin{aligned} 2\sqrt{ay_a} &= \ell - \frac{1}{2} \log \ell + C(0) \\ &\quad + \frac{\frac{1}{4} \log \ell - \frac{1}{2} C(0) + 3/8}{\ell} + O\left(\frac{(\log \ell)^2}{\ell^2} + \frac{(\log a)^2}{a}\right). \end{aligned} \quad (31)$$

*Proof.* With  $U_r = U_r(a)$ ,  $aH_a(x^2/a) = x \sum_{r \geq 0} U_r x^{2r+1}/(r!(r+1)!)$ , so Lemma 3.2(b) and the second identity of Lemma 3.2(c) give (30). Put  $x_a = \sqrt{ay_a}$ , so  $aH_a(x_a^2/a) = a$ , and  $x_a < \log a$  for large  $a$  by (30). So  $a \leq G_0(x_a) \leq a/(1 - x_a^2/(2a))$ , and as in Corollary 4.4,  $x_a - x_0 = O((\log a)^2/a)$ , where  $G_0(x_0) = a$ . So  $z = 2x_0$  satisfies  $z + \frac{1}{2} \log z = \ell + C(0) + 3/(8z) + O(z^{-2})$  by [21, Eq. 10.40.1], as in the proof of Theorem 4.7 with  $\eta = 0$  and  $A = a$ , and Lemma 4.6 gives the expansion.  $\square$

Figure 3 compares these laws with the exact crossings.

## 4.5 The moving boundary layer

The crossings also give the shape of a whole row at odds  $u = v_N > 0$ . Between the central crossing ( $v_N$  about  $(\log N)/N$ ) and the adjacent one ( $v_N$  about  $N^{-1/2}$ ), the middle is above the endpoints and a layer of bins next to each edge is below them. The width of this layer is

$$\mathcal{L}_N = \#\{1 \leq k \leq \lfloor N/2 \rfloor : P_N(k) < P_N(0)\}.$$

**Corollary 4.10** (boundary-layer width). *Suppose that, as  $N \rightarrow \infty$ ,*

$$\Omega_N = \frac{1}{\sqrt{N} v_N} \rightarrow \infty, \quad \frac{\log \Omega_N}{N v_N} \rightarrow 0.$$

*Then*

$$\mathcal{L}_N \sim \Omega_N^2 \log^2 \Omega_N = \frac{\log^2(1/(\sqrt{N} v_N))}{N v_N^2}. \quad (32)$$

*In particular, if  $v_N = N^{-\kappa}$  with  $1/2 < \kappa < 1$ , then*

$$\mathcal{L}_N \sim (\kappa - \frac{1}{2})^2 N^{2\kappa-1} \log^2 N.$$

*By symmetry, the total number of interior bins below the endpoint height is  $2\mathcal{L}_N$  for all sufficiently large  $N$ .*

*Proof.* Set  $d_N = \Omega_N^2 \log^2 \Omega_N$ . Then  $d_N \rightarrow \infty$  and  $d_N/N = (\log \Omega_N/(N v_N))^2 \rightarrow 0$ . Fix  $\theta \in (0, 1)$  and integers  $a_{\pm} = (1 \pm \theta)d_N + O(1)$ . Then  $\log a_{\pm} \sim 2 \log \Omega_N$  and  $\sqrt{a_{\pm}(N - a_{\pm})} v_N \sim \sqrt{1 \pm \theta} \log \Omega_N$ , so (23) gives  $u_{a_{\pm}, N-a_{\pm}}/v_N \rightarrow 1/\sqrt{1 \pm \theta}$ . Bin  $k$  is below the endpoint exactly when  $v_N < u_{k, N-k}$ , and  $u_{k, N-k}$  decreases strictly for  $k \leq N/2$  by Proposition 4.1. So  $a_- \leq \mathcal{L}_N < a_+$  for large  $N$ , and we let  $\theta \downarrow 0$ . Finally  $\mathcal{L}_N = o(N)$ , so the reflected intervals are disjoint.  $\square$

## 5 Periodic boundaries and the crossing window

We keep the line of bins but close the sequence of steps into a loop, so that the last step also interacts with the first. This is different from wrapping the board into a cylinder. With this closing bond the spins form the periodic Ising chain, with weight proportional to  $\exp(J \sum_{i=1}^N \sigma_i \sigma_{i+1})$ ,  $\sigma_{N+1} = \sigma_1$  and again  $u = e^{-2J}$ . Antal, Droz and Rácz [5] give its magnetization law at a fixed scale, and Dantchev and Rudnick [9] give exact coefficients. We find how much the closing bond moves the central crossing, and then describe the row near the crossing under both boundaries.

Write  $S_{N,k}^F = S_{k, N-k}$  and  $S_{N,k}^P$  for the bin-to-endpoint ratios under free and periodic boundaries. Put  $a = k$ ,  $b = N - k$  and  $s = \sqrt{ab}$ . Counting cyclic words by their runs gives

$$S_{N,k}^P(u) = \sum_{r=1}^{\min(a,b)} \frac{N}{r} \binom{a-1}{r-1} \binom{b-1}{r-1} u^{2r}. \quad (33)$$

To see this, note that a cyclic word with  $a$  letters  $+$  and  $b$  letters  $-$  switches an even number  $2r$  of times and has  $r$  runs of each letter. Choose compositions of  $a$  and of  $b$  into  $r$  positive runs and a position for the start of a distinguished run of letters  $+$ , and divide by the  $r$  choices of that run. The normalization of the periodic measure cancels in the ratio. In particular  $S_{N,1}^P = Nu^2$ , which gives the adjacent crossing  $J = (\log N)/4$  of Stepanyan et al. [19]. Every interior ratio increases strictly from 0 to  $\infty$  in  $u > 0$ , and the ratios increase strictly toward the middle, apart from the symmetric middle tie, by the coefficient comparison of Proposition 4.1.

**Theorem 5.1** (periodic relative error). *For  $N \geq 2$ ,  $1 \leq k \leq N - 1$ , and  $u > 0$ , define*

$$\hat{S}_{N,k}^P(u) = \frac{Nu}{\sqrt{k(N-k)}} I_1\left(2u\sqrt{k(N-k)}\right).$$

*Then*

$$0 \leq 1 - \frac{S_{N,k}^P(u)}{\hat{S}_{N,k}^P(u)} \leq \frac{Nu^2}{2}. \quad (34)$$

So under periodic boundaries every bin is a single Bessel function  $I_1$ , with the same kind of error as in Theorem 4.3.

*Proof.* Put  $x = su$ ,  $A = ab/N$ ,  $U_r = U_r(a)$  and  $V_r = U_r(b)$ . Shifting the index in (33) gives  $S_{N,k}^P(u) = (Nu/s) \sum_{r \geq 0} U_r V_r x^{2r+1}/(r!(r+1)!)$ , so the ratio to  $\hat{S}_{N,k}^P$  is an average of the  $U_r V_r$  with weights  $x^{2r+1}/(r!(r+1)!)$ , whose sum is  $I_1(2x)$ . By (15),  $0 \leq 1 - U_r V_r \leq r(r+1)/(2A)$ , and the second identity of Lemma 3.2(c) bounds the deficit by  $x^2/(2A) = Nu^2/2$ .  $\square$

The following heuristic explains the next theorem. A cyclic word switches an even number of times, so only  $I_1$  appears in the periodic approximation, while the free words that start and end on different letters give the extra  $I_0$  term of the free one. As  $I_0 \approx I_1$  for large arguments, the free ratio is about twice the periodic one near the crossing. Both grow like  $e^{Nu}$ , so the periodic crossing needs  $Nu$  about  $\log 2$  larger. Antal, Droz and Rácz [5, Eqs. (37) and (47)] work at a fixed value of  $T = Nq$  (their  $\theta = Nt/2$  with  $t = 1 - \tanh J$ ). There the endpoint atoms are  $1/(2 \cosh T)$  (periodic) and  $e^{-T}/2$  (free), which again differ by a factor of about 2 for large  $T$ , while their densities at zero magnetization agree to leading order as  $T \rightarrow \infty$ .

**Theorem 5.2** (periodic crossing and boundary shift). *Let  $u_N^P$  be the positive root of  $S_{N,m_N}^P(u) = 1$ , let  $p_N^P = 1/(1 + u_N^P)$ , and let  $u_N^F = u_N$  be the free central root. Put  $c_P = \frac{1}{2} \log(\pi/2)$ . As  $N \rightarrow \infty$ ,*

$$Nu_N^P = L - \frac{1}{2} \log L + c_P + \frac{\frac{1}{4} \log L - \frac{1}{2} c_P + \frac{3}{8}}{L} + O\left(\frac{(\log L)^2}{L^2}\right), \quad (35)$$

$$N(u_N^P - u_N^F) = \log 2 + \frac{\frac{1}{4} - \frac{1}{2} \log 2}{\log N} + o(1/\log N). \quad (36)$$

*Replacing  $Nu_N^P$  by  $N(1 - p_N^P)$  preserves (35). At the periodic crossing the coupling  $J_N^P = -\frac{1}{2} \log u_N^P$  satisfies*

$$J_N^P = \frac{1}{2}(\log N - \log \log N) + \frac{\frac{1}{4} \log \log N - \frac{1}{2} c_P}{\log N} + O\left(\frac{(\log \log N)^2}{(\log N)^2}\right). \quad (37)$$

Since  $c_P = c_0 + \log 2$ , the periodic expansion is the free one shifted by  $\log 2$ , with  $\frac{3}{8}$  in place of  $\frac{1}{8}$  in the  $1/L$  term.

*Proof. Step 1. The first order.* At the middle  $2s = N + O(1/N)$ . At  $u = (1 \pm \theta)L/N$  with fixed  $\theta \in (0, 1)$  the bound of Theorem 5.1 tends to 0, and the large-argument form of  $I_1$  makes  $\hat{S}^P$  tend to  $\infty$  with the plus sign and to 0 with the minus sign. Since  $S_{N,m_N}^P$  increases in  $u$ , we get  $Nu_N^P \sim L$ .

*Step 2. The crossing equation.* Write  $z = Nu_N^P$ . At the root  $S^P = 1$ , so  $\log \hat{S}^P = O(L^2/N)$  by (34). Replacing the argument  $2su$  by  $z$ , and the factor  $Nu/s$  by  $2z/N$ , changes  $\log \hat{S}^P$  by  $O(L/N^2)$ , and  $I_1(z) = e^z(2\pi z)^{-1/2}(1 - 3/(8z) + O(z^{-2}))$  [21, Eq. 10.40.1]. So

$$z + \frac{1}{2} \log z = L + c_P + \frac{3}{8z} + O(z^{-2} + L^2/N),$$

and Lemma 4.6 with  $\ell = L$ ,  $C = c_P$  and  $B = \frac{3}{8}$  gives (35). As  $N(u - u/(1+u)) = O(L^2/N)$  for  $Nu = O(L)$ , it also holds for  $N(1 - p_N^P)$ .

*Step 3. The shift and the coupling.* By (2),  $Nu_N = z_N + O(L^2/N)$ . Subtracting (11), where  $c_0 = c_P - \log 2$  and the correction is  $\frac{1}{8}$ , gives (36), even with error  $O((\log L)^2/L^2)$ . Finally  $J = -\frac{1}{2} \log u = \frac{1}{2}(L - \log z)$ , and  $\log z = \log L - (\frac{1}{2} \log L - c_P)/L + O((\log L)^2/L^2)$  gives (37).  $\square$

Stepanyan et al. [19, Eq. (16)] approximate the periodic crossing by  $\beta J \approx (2 \log N - 1)/5$ , and their Fig. 1(b) fits the line  $\beta J \approx 0.3864 \log N - 0.21055$ . At  $N = 10^5$  the exact periodic crossing is  $J = 4.576$  (their  $\beta J$ ). Their Eq. (16) gives 4.405, their line gives 4.238, and (37) without its error term gives 4.578. The line is accurate for  $10 \leq N \leq 100$  (at  $N = 100$  it gives 1.569 and the exact value is 1.574), but it has no  $\log \log N$  term.

Next we describe the whole row near the crossing. The factor  $e^{-2y^2}$  in the next theorem has a simple heuristic. Moving  $yN/\sqrt{\log N}$  away from the middle multiplies the Bessel argument by  $2\sqrt{k(N-k)}/N \approx 1 - 2y^2/\log N$ . The argument is about  $\log N$ , so it drops by about  $2y^2$ , and the ratio, which grows like  $e$  to the argument, drops by about the factor  $e^{-2y^2}$ .

**Theorem 5.3** (spatial crossing window). *Let  $X \in \{F, P\}$  and let  $u_N^X$  be its exact central crossing. For fixed real  $t, y$  set*

$$u = u_N^X + \frac{t}{N}, \quad k_N(y) = \text{nint}\left(\frac{N}{2} + \frac{yN}{\sqrt{\log N}}\right),$$

where either nearest-integer convention may be used. Then, as  $N \rightarrow \infty$ , uniformly on compact sets of  $(t, y)$ ,

$$S_{N, k_N(y)}^X(u_N^X + t/N) \longrightarrow e^{t-2y^2}. \quad (38)$$

If  $M_N^X(t)$  is the number of interior bins with probability strictly above the endpoint probability at that parameter, then

$$\frac{\sqrt{\log N}}{N} M_N^X(t) \longrightarrow \sqrt{2 \max(t, 0)}. \quad (39)$$

So the crossing window has width about  $1/N$  in  $u$  and about  $N/\sqrt{\log N}$  in space, and inside it the row is a Gaussian bump times  $e^t$ . A weak limit theorem cannot give this, since it says nothing about a single bin such as the endpoint.

*Proof. Step 1. The profile.* Put  $\lambda = k/N - \frac{1}{2}$  and  $\eta = 2\sqrt{k(N-k)}/N = \sqrt{1 - 4\lambda^2}$ . For the stated rounding and bounded  $y$ ,

$$\eta = 1 - \frac{2y^2}{L} + O\left(L^{-2} + \frac{1}{N\sqrt{L}}\right), \quad Nu_N^X = L + O(\log L).$$

So the Bessel argument  $Nu\eta$  at  $(u, k)$  is  $Nu_N^X + t - 2y^2 + o(1)$ , uniformly on the compact set. By Theorems 4.3 and 5.1 both ratios are within relative error  $O(L^2/N)$  of their Bessel forms, and  $I_0(z)$  and  $I_1(z)$  equal  $e^z(2\pi z)^{-1/2}(1 + O(1/z))$  [21, Eq. 10.40.1], so the prefactors relative to their central values tend to 1 uniformly. The change of argument gives  $e^{t-2y^2}$ , and the exact central ratio is 1, which proves (38).

*Step 2. The count.* The interior ratios increase toward the middle, by Proposition 4.1 for  $X = F$  and by the coefficient comparison after (33) for  $X = P$ . If  $t \leq 0$ , the central ratio is at most 1, so no interior bin is above the endpoint. Let  $t > 0$  and  $0 < \theta < \sqrt{t}/2$ . By Step 1, for large  $N$  the bins at scaled distance less than  $\sqrt{t}/2 - \theta$  are above the endpoint and those at distance  $\sqrt{t}/2 + \theta$  are below, and by monotonicity so are all farther bins. Count the bins in between, divide by  $N/\sqrt{L}$  and let  $\theta \downarrow 0$ . Rounding changes the count by  $O(1)$ .  $\square$

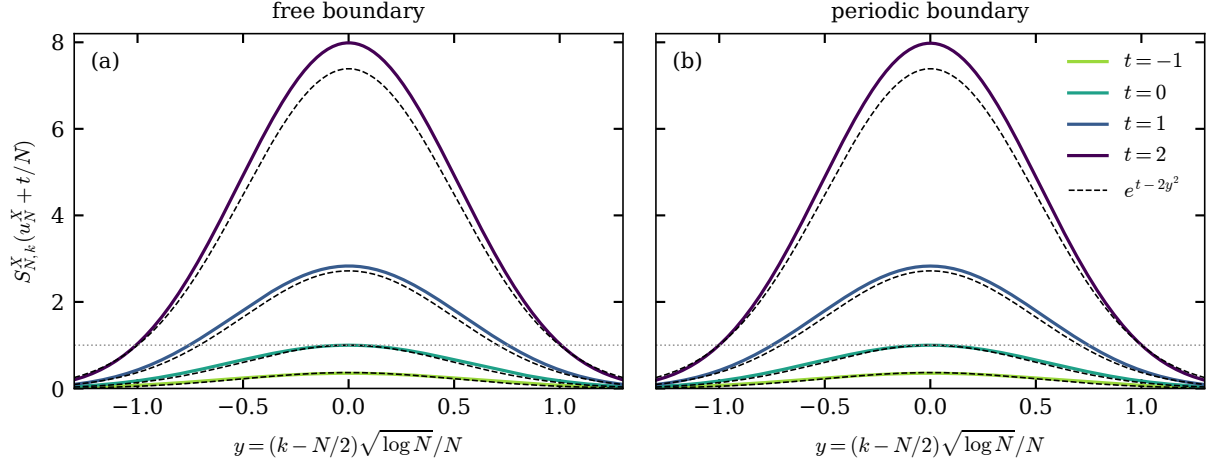


Figure 4: The exact ratios  $S_{N,k}^X(u_N^X + t/N)$  at  $N = 10^6$  for free (a) and periodic (b) boundaries, with the limit  $e^{t-2y^2}$  of Theorem 5.3 (dashed). Here  $y = (k - N/2)\sqrt{\log N}/N$ , and the bins above the dotted line are above the endpoint height. The convergence is slow, and at  $t = 2$  and  $y = 0$  the relative error is still 0.08.

Figure 4 shows the exact ratios at  $N = 10^6$ .

## 6 Verification

Apart from Remark 3.9, which is computer-assisted throughout, the proofs use two computations, each described where it is used. They are the integer certificates for  $N \leq 174$  in Theorem 3.4 (Step 4) and Proposition 3.8, and the evaluation at  $N = 2774$  in Corollary 3.7(d). The scripts are standard-library Python. They check the exact law, the orderings, the Bessel bounds and the asymptotic formulas, and where possible each reported number is computed in two independent ways.

Many of the results are formalized in Lean 4, in the folder `kagey-problems/problem131/lean/PaperA`. This includes Theorem 3.4 for all  $N \geq 2$ . For  $N \leq 174$  the Lean kernel checks the same certificates as Step 4 of its proof, with rational bounds on  $\zeta_N$  that Lean proves itself. Only the standard axioms are used. Not formalized are Proposition 3.8, the remarks, and the terms after the leading one in the asymptotic results. The file `MAP.md` in that folder gives the Lean theorem for each result, or says that there is none.

**Data and code availability.** Everything is in the folder `kagey-problems/problem131` of <https://github.com/apemm/Kagey-Problems>, at the release `paperA-arxiv-v1`. To rerun the checks, run `python-Bverify_all.py--papera` in that folder. The file `SUPPLEMENT.md` says what each script does. The certificates for Theorem 3.4 are in `paperA/data/every_n_certificates.csv`, and the numbers in Sections 3 and 5 that no script prints are in `paperA/data/quoted_values.txt`.

**Acknowledgment.** I thank Peter Kagey for posing the problem.

## A note on the use of AI

I used Claude (Anthropic, model Opus 5.5, through Claude Code) in September and October 2026. It wrote the Lean 4 formalization in `kagey-problems/problem131/lean/PaperA` from the statements of the paper, and I checked each Lean statement against the corresponding result (see `MAP.md` in that folder). It wrote parts of the Python verification scripts and cross-checked them, it revised the wording of the paper, and it checked the proofs. I also used it for literature search and to check sources beyond the literature I had first checked on my own.

It also suggested the elementary bounds on  $I_0 + I_1$  in Lemma 3.6 (the Bessel lemma used for the crossing at every  $N$ ), which I verified. It did not always get things right. Some of the values it predicted before a computation turned out to be wrong, and an early version of one check script had a precision bug, which was found and fixed.

All mathematical claims, proofs and computations in this paper are my responsibility.

## A The crossing at every $N$

This appendix proves Lemma 3.6, the analytic half of Theorem 3.4, the identity behind the certificates and Proposition 3.8. In it the letters  $U, U', W, W', r, r', t, t', \tau, \kappa, m, B, D, \beta, \Delta$  and  $\delta$  have the local meanings given below. Each decimal constant is rounded in the safe direction.

### A.1 Proof of Lemma 3.6

For integer  $n$ ,  $I_n(z) = \frac{1}{\pi} \int_0^\pi e^{z \cos t} \cos(nt) dt$  [21, Eq. 10.32.3], so  $I_0(z) + I_1(z) = \frac{1}{\pi} \int_0^\pi e^{z \cos t} (1 + \cos t) dt$ . Substitute  $s = 1 - \cos t$ , so that  $\sin t = \sqrt{s(2-s)}$  and  $1 + \cos t = 2 - s$ , and then  $s = v/z$ . This gives

$$\mathcal{E}(z) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{\pi}} \int_0^{2z} e^{-v} v^{-1/2} \sqrt{1 - \frac{v}{2z}} dv. \quad (40)$$

On  $[0, 1]$  we have  $\sqrt{1-y} = 1 - \sum_{k \geq 1} c_k y^k$  with every  $c_k > 0$ ,  $c_1 = \frac{1}{2}$  and  $c_2 = \frac{1}{8}$ , and  $\sum_k c_k = 1$  by monotone convergence as  $y \uparrow 1$ . So  $\sum_{k \geq 3} c_k = \frac{3}{8}$ , and  $y^k \leq y^3$  gives  $\sum_{k \geq 3} c_k y^k \leq \frac{3}{8} y^3$ . Hence, for  $0 \leq y \leq 1$ ,

$$g_-(y) := 1 - \frac{y}{2} - \frac{y^2}{8} - \frac{3y^3}{8} \leq \sqrt{1-y} \leq 1 - \frac{y}{2} - \frac{y^2}{8} \leq g_+(y) := 1 - \frac{y}{2} - \frac{y^2}{8} + \frac{y^3}{8}.$$

The cubic  $g_-$  decreases and  $g_-(1) = 0$ , so  $g_- \leq 0$  on  $[1, \infty)$ . Also  $8g_+(y) = (y-2)^2(y+1) + 2(y-1)^2 + 2 > 0$  for  $y \geq -1$ . Put  $y = v/(2z)$  in (40), replace  $\sqrt{1-y}$  by  $g_\pm$  and extend the integral to  $\infty$ . The added piece is at most 0 with  $g_-$  and at least 0 with  $g_+$ , so the lower bound survives with  $g_-$  and the upper with  $g_+$ . Since  $\frac{1}{\sqrt{\pi}} \int_0^\infty e^{-v} v^{k-1/2} dv = \Gamma(k + \frac{1}{2})/\Gamma(\frac{1}{2})$  equals  $1, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{3}{4}, \frac{15}{8}$  for  $k = 0, 1, 2, 3$ , the two bounds integrate to the two sides of the lemma. The bound  $\mathcal{E} \leq 1$  follows in the same way from  $\sqrt{1-y} \leq 1$ . Finally  $-\frac{3}{128z^2} + \frac{15}{512z^3} \leq 0$  exactly when  $z \geq \frac{5}{4}$ .

### A.2 Proof of Theorem 3.4 for $N \geq 175$

*Step 1. Bounds that hold for every  $\zeta \geq 4$ .* Fix  $N \geq 175$  and write  $\zeta = \zeta_N$ ,  $U = \zeta + \frac{1}{8\zeta}$ ,  $r = U/N$  and  $n(\zeta) = \sqrt{8\zeta/\pi} e^\zeta$ . Then  $n(\zeta_N) = N$  by (8), and  $\zeta \geq 4$  since  $n(4) < 175$ . For  $k = 1, 2, 3$  the function  $U^k/n(\zeta)$  decreases on  $[4, \infty)$ , because its logarithmic derivative is  $k(1 - \frac{1}{8\zeta^2})/U - 1 - \frac{1}{2\zeta} < \frac{k}{U} - 1 < 0$ .

The same holds for  $U^4/n$ , since  $U > 4$ , and for  $\zeta/n$  and  $\zeta^2/n$ . The values at  $\zeta = 4$  give, for every  $\zeta \geq 4$ ,

$$r \leq 0.023135, \quad \frac{U^2}{N} \leq 0.093262, \quad \frac{U^3}{N} \leq 0.375960, \quad \frac{U^4}{N} \leq 1.51559, \quad \frac{\zeta(\zeta+1)}{N} \leq 0.114776.$$

*Step 2. The upper bound.* Let  $W = U/(1-r)$ , so that  $NW/(N+W) = U$ , and let  $\delta = W(W+2)/(2N)$ . By Lemma 3.5(b) and (9) it suffices to show that  $G_U := \psi(W) - \psi(\zeta) + \log \mathcal{E}(W) + \log(1-\delta) > 0$ . We bound the three parts from below. First,  $\psi(W) - \psi(\zeta) = (W-U) + (U-\zeta) + \frac{1}{2} \log \frac{U}{\zeta} + \frac{1}{2} \log \frac{W}{U}$ , where  $W-U = \frac{Ur}{1-r}$ ,  $U-\zeta = \frac{1}{8\zeta}$ ,  $\log \frac{U}{\zeta} = \log(1 + \frac{1}{8\zeta^2}) \geq \frac{1}{8\zeta^2} - \frac{1}{128\zeta^4}$  and  $\log \frac{W}{U} = -\log(1-r) \geq r$ . Second, Lemma 3.6 gives  $\mathcal{E}(W) \geq 1-t$  with  $t = \frac{1}{8W} + \frac{3}{128W^2} + \frac{45}{512W^3}$ . Since  $W \geq U \geq \zeta$  and  $\frac{1}{8U} = \frac{1}{8\zeta} - \frac{1}{8\zeta(8\zeta^2+1)} \leq \frac{1}{8\zeta} - \frac{1}{64\zeta^3} + \frac{1}{512\zeta^5}$ , we get  $t \leq \tau := \frac{1}{8\zeta} + \frac{3}{128\zeta^2} + \frac{37}{512\zeta^3} + \frac{1}{512\zeta^5}$  and  $\log \mathcal{E}(W) \geq \log(1-\tau) \geq -\tau - \frac{\tau^2}{2(1-\tau)}$ . Third,  $\delta = \frac{Ur}{2(1-r)^2} + \frac{r}{1-r}$  and  $\log(1-\delta) \geq -\delta - \frac{\delta^2}{2(1-\delta)}$ . Adding the three parts gives  $G_U \geq B + D$ , where  $B$  collects the terms in  $\zeta$  alone and  $D$  the terms with a factor  $r$ ,

$$B = \frac{5}{128\zeta^2} - \frac{37}{512\zeta^3} - \frac{1}{256\zeta^4} - \frac{1}{512\zeta^5} - \frac{\tau^2}{2(1-\tau)}, \quad D = \frac{r}{2(1-r)} \left( \frac{U(1-2r)}{1-r} - 1 - r \right) - \frac{\delta^2}{2(1-\delta)}.$$

Both  $\zeta\tau$  and  $\tau$  decrease in  $\zeta$ , so  $\zeta^2B$  increases. At  $\zeta = 4$  we have  $\zeta\tau = 0.135384$ ,  $\tau = 0.033846$  and  $\zeta^2B = 0.011236$ . Hence  $B > 0$ . In  $D$  the bracket is at least  $4.03125(1-0.023683) - 1.023135 > 2.912$ , so the first term of  $D$  is at least  $1.456r$ . Write  $\delta = rm$  with  $m = \frac{U}{2(1-r)^2} + \frac{1}{1-r}$ . Then  $\delta \leq 0.07255$  and  $rm^2 = \frac{U^3}{4N(1-r)^4} + \frac{U^2}{N(1-r)^3} + \frac{r}{(1-r)^2} \leq 0.2276$ , so  $\frac{\delta^2}{2(1-\delta)} = r \cdot \frac{rm^2}{2(1-\delta)} \leq 0.1228r$ . Hence  $D \geq 1.33r > 0$ . So  $G_U > 0$  and  $z_N < U$ .

*Step 3. The lower bound.* Let  $\varepsilon = \varepsilon_N$ ,  $U' = U - \varepsilon$ ,  $r' = U'/N$  and  $W' = U'/(1-r')$ , so that  $NW'/(N+W') = U'$ . By Step 1,  $\varepsilon \leq 0.114776 + \frac{1}{256} < 0.1187$ , so  $U' \geq \zeta - 0.1187 \geq 3.88$  and  $W' \geq U'$ . By Lemma 3.5(a) and (9) it suffices to show that  $G_{U'} := \psi(W') - \psi(\zeta) + \log \mathcal{E}(W') < 0$ . We bound the two parts from above. First,  $\psi(W') - \psi(\zeta) = (U' - \zeta) + \frac{U'r'}{1-r'} + \frac{1}{2} \log \frac{U'}{\zeta} - \frac{1}{2} \log(1-r')$ , where  $U' - \zeta = \frac{1}{8\zeta} - \varepsilon$ ,  $\frac{1}{2} \log \frac{U'}{\zeta} \leq \frac{1}{2} \left( \frac{U'}{\zeta} - 1 \right) = \frac{1}{16\zeta^2} - \frac{\varepsilon}{2\zeta}$  and  $-\frac{1}{2} \log(1-r') \leq \frac{r'}{2(1-r')}$ . The two terms in  $r'$  add up to  $\frac{U'^2 + U'/2}{N(1-r')}$ . Second, Lemma 3.6 gives  $\mathcal{E}(W') \leq 1-t'$  with  $t' = \frac{1}{8W'} + \frac{3}{128W'^2} - \frac{15}{512W'^3} \in (0, 1)$ , so  $\log \mathcal{E}(W') \leq -t'$ . Here  $\frac{1}{8W'} = \frac{1}{8U'} - \frac{1}{8N}$ . Write  $U' = \zeta(1+\kappa)$  with  $\kappa = \frac{1}{8\zeta^2} - \frac{\varepsilon}{\zeta}$ . Then  $\frac{1}{U'} \geq \frac{1-\kappa}{\zeta}$ , so  $-\frac{1}{8W'} \leq -\frac{1}{8\zeta} + \frac{1}{64\zeta^3} - \frac{\varepsilon}{8\zeta^2} + \frac{1}{8N}$ . Next,  $x \mapsto x/(1-x/N)$  increases and  $U' \leq U$ , so  $W' \leq U/(1-r)$  and  $\frac{1}{W'^2} \geq \frac{(1-r)^2}{\zeta^2(1+\frac{1}{8\zeta^2})^2} \geq \frac{(1-2r)(1-\frac{1}{4\zeta^2})}{\zeta^2}$ . Finally  $\frac{15}{512W'^3} \leq \frac{15}{512U'^3}$ . Adding, and using  $\varepsilon(1 + \frac{1}{2\zeta}) = \frac{\zeta^2 + \frac{3}{2}\zeta + \frac{1}{2}}{N} + \frac{1}{16\zeta^2} + \frac{1}{32\zeta^3}$ , we get  $G_{U'} \leq \beta + \Delta - \frac{\varepsilon}{8\zeta^2}$  with

$$\beta = -\frac{3}{128\zeta^2}(1-2r) \left( 1 - \frac{1}{4\zeta^2} \right) + \frac{15}{512U'^3} - \frac{1}{64\zeta^3}, \quad \Delta = \frac{1}{N} \left( \frac{U'^2 + U'/2}{1-r'} + \frac{1}{8} - \zeta^2 - \frac{3}{2}\zeta - \frac{1}{2} \right).$$

For  $\beta < 0$  it suffices that  $\zeta^2/U'^3 \leq \frac{4}{5}(1-2r)(1 - \frac{1}{4\zeta^2})$ . The left side is at most  $\zeta^2/(\zeta - 0.12)^3 \leq 16/3.88^3 < 0.274$ , since this function decreases for  $\zeta > 0.12$  (its logarithmic derivative is  $\frac{2}{\zeta} - \frac{3}{\zeta-0.12} < 0$  there). The right side is at least  $0.8 \cdot 0.9537 \cdot 0.9843 > 0.75$ . For  $\Delta < 0$ , note that  $U' \leq U$  and  $r' \leq r$ , so

$$\frac{U'^2 + U'/2}{1-r'} \leq U^2 + \frac{U}{2} + \frac{U^3/N + U^2/(2N)}{1-r} \leq \zeta^2 + \frac{\zeta}{2} + 0.2667 + 0.4326,$$

using  $U^2 + \frac{U}{2} = \zeta^2 + \frac{\zeta}{2} + \frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{16\zeta} + \frac{1}{64\zeta^2}$ . This is less than  $\zeta^2 + \frac{3}{2}\zeta + \frac{3}{8}$  because  $\zeta \geq 4$ . Hence  $G_{U'} < 0$  and  $z_N > U'$ .

The constants were recomputed in 40-digit arithmetic, and as a check outside the proof we evaluated  $\zeta^2 B$ ,  $D$ ,  $\beta$  and  $\Delta$  on  $\zeta \in [4, 60]$  with step 0.001.

### A.3 The certificates

Let  $c, d > 0$  be integers. Multiplying (6) by  $d^{N-1}$  gives

$$d^{N-1} S_N(c/d) = \sum_j W(N, m_N, j) c^j d^{N-1-j},$$

an integer. By Theorem 2.1 it is the sum of  $d^{\text{rep}(w)} c^{\text{chg}(w)}$  over the words  $w$  in bin  $m_N$ , that is, the numerator  $n_N(m_N)$  of Remark 2.3 with  $(\alpha, \beta) = (d, c)$ . The recursion (3) with the weights  $d, c$  in place of  $p, q$  and initial values 1 computes the same sums. So  $S_N(c/d) < 1$  exactly when this integer is less than  $d^{N-1}$ . This is the identity used in Step 4 of the proof of Theorem 3.4.

### A.4 Proof of Proposition 3.8

*Step 1. An exact formula for  $R_N$ .* Write  $w = w_N$ ,  $z = z_N$ ,  $\Lambda_N = 2\Phi(w)/N$  and  $\delta = w(w+2)/(2N)$ . At  $w = w_N$  the display in the proof of Lemma 3.5 gives  $1 \leq \Lambda_N \leq 1/(1-\delta)$  when  $\delta < 1$ , and (9) gives  $\psi(w) + \log \mathcal{E}(w) = L + c_0 + \log \Lambda_N$ . Since  $w - z = wz/N$ ,  $w/z = 1 + w/N$  and  $\frac{1}{8z} = \frac{1}{8w} + \frac{1}{8N}$ , the remainder  $R_N = \psi(z) - L - c_0 - \frac{1}{8z}$  is

$$R_N = \log \Lambda_N - \left( \log \mathcal{E}(w) + \frac{1}{8w} \right) - \frac{1}{8N} - \frac{wz}{N} - \frac{1}{2} \log \left( 1 + \frac{w}{N} \right). \quad (41)$$

*Step 2. The lower bound for  $N \geq 175$ .* By the proof of Theorem 3.4,  $3.88 \leq z \leq w \leq U/(1-r)$ . Note that  $\log \Lambda_N \geq 0$  and  $-\log \mathcal{E}(w) \geq -\log(1 - \frac{1}{8w}) \geq \frac{1}{8w}$  by Lemma 3.6, since  $w \geq \frac{5}{4}$ . So  $R_N \geq -\frac{wz+w/2+1/8}{N} = -\frac{z^2+z/2}{N-z} - \frac{1}{8N}$ . This is at least  $-\frac{z^2+z}{N}$  as soon as  $N \geq \frac{2z^2(z+1)}{z-1/4}$ . The right side increases in  $z$  and  $z \leq U$ , so it suffices that  $U^2/N \leq \frac{U-1/4}{2(U+1)}$ . The left side is at most 0.0933 and the right side at least 0.3757.

*Step 3. The upper bound for  $N \geq 175$ .* Let  $t = \frac{1}{8w} + \frac{3}{128w^2} + \frac{45}{512w^3} \leq \frac{1.09504}{8w}$ , which holds as  $w \geq 3.88$ . Lemma 3.6 and  $-\log(1-t) \leq t + \frac{t^2}{2(1-t)}$  give

$$-\log \mathcal{E}(w) - \frac{1}{8w} \leq \frac{3}{128w^2} + \frac{45}{512w^3} + \frac{t^2}{2(1-t)} \leq \frac{0.0559}{w^2} \leq \frac{0.0559}{z^2}.$$

Using  $\log \Lambda_N \leq \delta + \frac{\delta^2}{2(1-\delta)}$ ,  $\log(1+x) \geq x - \frac{x^2}{2}$  and  $wz \geq w^2 - w^3/N$ , the rest of (41) is at most  $-\frac{(w-1/2)^2}{2N} + \frac{w^3+w^2/4}{N^2} + \frac{\delta^2}{2(1-\delta)}$ . By the bounds on  $r$  and  $U^k/N$  in Step 1 of the previous proof, with  $w \leq U/(1-r)$ , we have  $\frac{w^3+w^2/4}{N} \leq 0.4278$  and  $N \frac{\delta^2}{2(1-\delta)} = \frac{(w^4+4w^3+4w^2)/(4N)}{2(1-\delta)} \leq 0.4945$ , while  $\frac{(w-1/2)^2}{2} \geq 5.71$ . So the rest is negative and  $R_N \leq 0.0559/z^2 < \frac{1}{16z^2}$ .

*Step 4. The form in  $L$  for  $N \geq 175$ .* We have  $z < U = L + c_0 - \frac{1}{2} \log \zeta + \frac{1}{8\zeta} < L$ . Also  $z > \zeta - 0.1187 \geq \nu_N - 0.1187 \geq L/2$ , because  $L - \log L \geq 1.18$  for  $L \geq \log 175$ . Then  $\frac{1}{16z^2} \leq \frac{1}{4L^2}$  and  $\frac{z^2+z}{N} \leq \frac{L^2+L}{N}$ .

*Step 5.  $N \leq 174$ .* The function  $\phi(z) = \psi(z) - L - c_0 - \frac{1}{8z}$  increases in  $z$ , and  $R_N = \phi(z_N)$ , while  $\frac{1}{16z^2}$  and  $-\frac{z^2+z}{N}$  decrease. So it suffices to check  $\phi(z(c'/d)) \leq \frac{1}{16z(c'/d)^2}$  and  $\phi(z(c/d)) \geq$

$-\frac{z(c/d)^2+z(c/d)}{N}$  with the certificates, together with  $z(c/d) \geq L/2$  and, for  $N \geq 3$ ,  $z(c'/d) \leq L$ . All hold, and the smallest gaps are 0.0373 (upper) and 0.0813 (lower), both at  $N = 174$ . For  $N = 2$  we have  $S_2(u) = 2u$ , so  $u_2 = \frac{1}{2}$  and  $z_2 = \frac{2}{3}$ , and  $\frac{2}{3} < \log 2$  is equivalent to  $e^2 < 8$ , which holds since  $e^2 < 2.72^2 = 7.3984$ .

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